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Table of Contents

Table of Contents **2**
Acronyms **4**
Executive Summary **5**
1. Understanding Digital Demand for Timor-Leste **7**
1.1 Positioning This Assessment Within Existing Tourism Efforts 7
1.2 Comparator Destinations & Rationale 8
1.3 Data Sources & Methodology 9
2. Interpreting Digital Signals of Travel Demand **10**
The Five Stages of the Digital Travel Journey 10
2.1 Global Visibility & Demand Signals for Timor-Leste 12
2.2 Google Trends Analysis 12
2.3 Global Search Interest & Seasonality 16
2.4 Keyword Demand & Intent Mapping 18
2.5 Search Volume vs. Planning Depth 21
2.6 Comparator Benchmarking: Demand & Visibility 23
2.7 What Global Visibility and Demand Signals Reveal 25
3. Sentiment Analysis: From Search Interest to Real Experience **26**
3.1 Methodology 26
3.2 Booking.com Insights 29
3.3 Tripadvisor Insights 38
3.4 Google Review Insights 43
3.5 Cross-Platform Synthesis 48
3. International Media and Influencer Narratives **52**
4.1 Media Coverage: Scope and Role 52
4.2 International Media Narratives 53
4.3 Influencer Narratives 56
4.4 Narrative Tensions & Gaps 59
4. Traveler Segments, Digital Behavior Signals, and Investment Relevance **61**
5.1 Product-Led Traveler Segmentation 61
5.2 Observed Digital Behavior Signals 63
5.3 Data Gaps and Validation Path 65
Bibliography **66**
Annex A: Media & Influencer Sources **67**
Annex B: Key Digital & Tourism Marketing Terms Used in This Report **70**

Acronyms

ASEAN – Association of Southeast Asian Nations

CRM – Customer Relationship Management

ITC – International Trade Centre

MTE – Ministry of Tourism and Environment

NLP – Natural Language Processing

PADI – Professional Association of Diving Instructors

PNG – Papua New Guinea

ROI – Return on Investment

Executive Summary

The Ministry of Tourism and Environment (MTE) of Timor-Leste, with technical support from the International Trade Centre (ITC), undertook this assessment to establish an evidence-based baseline of Timor-Leste's digital visibility, visitor perception, and competitive positioning as input to national tourism development planning.

The analysis examines how Timor-Leste is discovered, evaluated, and discussed by international travelers across search engines, online travel platforms, and international media. It draws on publicly available digital data, including global search behavior, more than 29,000 visitor reviews from Tripadvisor, Booking.com, and Google Maps, and a structured review of international media and influencer content. Together, these sources provide a coherent view of external demand signals and visitor experience. Subsequent phases will build on this foundation using destination-owned data to refine prioritization and inform actionable recommendations for the Tourism Roadmap.

Key Findings

1. **Timor-Leste is visible, but primarily as a destination to learn about rather than to plan for**

Global search data shows detectable international awareness, particularly in Australia, but interest is episodic rather than sustained. Most searches are informational—focused on geography, identity, and basic orientation—with limited progression into planning behaviors such as itinerary design or trip sequencing. Compared with regional peers, Timor-Leste shows weaker depth in planning demand, pointing to a progression challenge rather than a lack of interest.

2. **Visitor experience is consistently strong across platforms, not fragmented**

Across Tripadvisor, Booking.com, and Google Maps, Timor-Leste receives positive overall ratings and sentiment. Differences between platforms reflect how experiences are evaluated rather than disagreement about quality. Longer reviews surface trade-offs and friction more clearly, while shorter reviews emphasize immediate satisfaction. Read together, these platforms describe a coherent and largely positive visitor experience.

3. **Diving, activities, and on-the-ground mobility are clear competitive strengths**

Marine and diving experiences emerge as Timor-Leste's strongest differentiators, outperforming regional competitors in sentiment and credibility. Activities and tours perform well when assessed through lived experience, and transport consistently exceeds expectations, reinforcing the perception that the destination is workable once visitors arrive. Beaches and scenery reinforce a "hidden gem" dynamic, with satisfaction highest when assets are directly encountered.

4. **Friction is real, but narrow and highly concentrated**

Negative narratives cluster around a small number of reliability issues, most notably WiFi, accommodation consistency, and breakfast quality. These issues reflect variability rather than systemic failure, but generate disproportionate negative language when expectations are not met. Despite this friction, families, couples, and solo travelers report high overall satisfaction.

5. **Narrative structure, not sentiment, is a constraint on demand**

International media and influencer coverage is positive and credible, validating Timor-Leste's authenticity, marine quality, and cultural depth. However, stories often emphasize effort or complexity before providing reassurance or practical clarity. Influencer content reinforces this through episodic storytelling that highlights moments rather than complete trips. As a result, audiences are shown that rewarding travel is possible, but not consistently shown what a typical visit looks like or how experiences connect. This favors adventurous travelers while limiting broader consideration.

Implications for Demand and Segmentation

Timor-Leste's tourism assets perform strongly and are valued by visitors. However, demand is constrained by limited planning-stage reassurance, uneven reliability in basic services, and narrative gaps that slow the transition from curiosity to confidence.

Observed digital behavior suggests distinct patterns by traveler segment:

- **Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Travelers:** Engage deeply with experiential content, tolerate early friction, and rely on peer and influencer validation rather than structured planning information.
- **Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Travelers:** Show high research sophistication and strong interest, but engagement frequently stalls where operational detail and reassurance are lacking.
- **Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented Travelers:** Respond to authenticity and editorial credibility, but hesitate when experiences are not presented as concrete, time-bound activities. Translating values into plannable experiences is key to unlocking this segment.
- **Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers:** Rely heavily on peer-to-peer information and often plan independently, reducing reliance on official channels and offering more limited potential for high-value growth.

Together, these signals establish a working hypothesis for how digital demand for Timor-Leste currently forms, advances, or stalls by segment. They point directly to priorities for destination storytelling, service reliability, and investment focus, and provide a clear foundation for validation in subsequent phases using destination-owned data.

1. Understanding Digital Demand for Timor-Leste

Understanding the digital demand for a tourism destination requires looking beyond stated preferences or policy intent to how interest actually forms in digital environments. These early digital signals, including what travelers search for and what appears, reveal not only whether a destination is known, but whether it is legible, compelling, and actionable in the moments when curiosity begins to solidify into travel consideration.

For destinations like Timor-Leste, digital demand offers a useful lens. Search behavior, online visibility, and content discovery patterns make it possible to observe how different audiences encounter the destination, which aspects attract attention, and where momentum stalls. Examining these signals helps clarify whether existing strategic ambitions are being reinforced by how the destination appears online, or whether gaps in visibility, reassurance, or structure are preventing interest from progressing.

1.1 Positioning This Assessment Within Existing Tourism Efforts

Timor-Leste has benefited from a substantial body of tourism policy, strategy, and market analysis over the past decade. National development plans, tourism policies, and donor-supported studies articulate a shared strategic direction: *positioning the country around niche, experience-driven tourism anchored in marine assets, cultural heritage, nature, and adventure*.

These strategic priorities are well established and broadly aligned across institutions. However, despite this clarity, tourism growth has remained constrained. A recurring theme across previous work is not uncertainty about what Timor-Leste offers, but difficulty translating strategic intent into sustained market demand, particularly through digital channels.

This digital assessment is designed to address that gap. Rather than redefining priority products or markets, it examines how Timor-Leste is currently discovered, evaluated, and validated online, and whether its digital presence supports the ambitions articulated in existing frameworks.

Specifically, the assessment asks whether the traveler segments and source markets identified in past strategies are meaningfully visible in today's digital demand signals—and, where they are, how effectively interest progresses from awareness to consideration and planning.

To answer this, the assessment focuses on three interrelated dimensions:

- **Destination visibility and reputation online** – how Timor-Leste is searched for, reviewed, and discussed across global digital platforms
- **Traveler segments and digital behaviors** – how priority segments discover, evaluate, and validate travel decisions online
- **Digital readiness and market activation potential** – whether current digital narratives and assets are sufficient to convert interest into visitation, relative to competing destinations

In doing so, this report complements existing tourism strategies by providing a demand-side diagnostic that helps explain where and why digital demand currently weakens—and where future efforts are most likely to unlock growth.

1.2 Comparator Destinations & Rationale

To assess Timor-Leste's destination visibility and reputation in a meaningful way, comparator destinations were selected to reflect the digital decision space in which potential travelers encounter, evaluate, and compare destinations. Selection was based not only on geographic proximity, but on product similarity, awareness level, and positioning within the Asia–Pacific travel market.

The objective is to understand how Timor-Leste performs relative to destinations that compete for similar traveler attention, motivations, and intent. This approach supports a benchmarking of digital demand, visibility, and perception.

Indonesia

With 13.8 million visits in 2024, Indonesia is included as one of the region's dominant tourism markets and a primary point of reference in global travel search behavior.

Including Indonesia allows the assessment to measure the awareness gap between Timor-Leste and a highly visible neighbor, and to distinguish between issues of absolute scale versus relative positioning. Analysis here helps clarify whether Timor-Leste is absent from traveler consideration entirely, or present but overshadowed within a broader regional narrative.

Papua New Guinea

The inclusion of Papua New Guinea with 132,275 international visitors in 2024 allows for a comparison between two destinations that face similar challenges around accessibility, infrastructure perception, and traveler confidence, but which differ in international brand recognition.

This comparison is valuable for understanding how niche destinations translate authenticity and uniqueness into digital demand and sustained interest.

Solomon Islands

Solomon Islands, with 25,130 visitors in 2024, is included as a structurally comparable small island destination, offering a closer parallel in terms of population size, tourism scale, and institutional capacity.

Unlike Indonesia, and even Papua New Guinea, the Solomon Islands provide a benchmark for how smaller destinations with limited marketing budgets perform digitally. This comparison helps isolate whether observed gaps in Timor-Leste's visibility and reputation are primarily driven by scale, or by differences in digital presence, storytelling, and market engagement.

1.3 Data Sources & Methodology

This assessment uses publicly available digital data to examine how Timor-Leste appears, performs, and is perceived across international digital channels. The approach is diagnostic rather than evaluative: it aims to identify patterns of visibility, perception, and friction in the digital travel journey, rather than to measure tourism performance or outcomes.

Three primary data streams underpin the analysis.

1. Search and keyword data are used to understand global awareness, seasonality, and how interest develops from general discovery toward planning.
2. Visitor review platforms provide large-scale insight into on-the-ground experience, highlighting strengths, common points of friction, and what visitors are willing to tolerate.
3. International media and influencer content are reviewed to understand how Timor-Leste is framed before a trip is considered, particularly in relation to access, effort, and perceived value.

Each data source is used to inform the stage of the travel decision process it best represents, and findings are interpreted in relation to one another rather than in isolation.

Comparator destinations are selected to reflect the digital environment in which Timor-Leste is typically encountered and evaluated. Benchmarking therefore focuses on relative patterns—such as depth of planning demand and narrative clarity—rather than on absolute scale.

At this stage, the assessment does not include internal or proprietary data. Website analytics, OTA performance data, campaign metrics, CRM data, and primary visitor surveys are expected in later phases and will be used to validate and refine the signals identified here. The findings in this report should therefore be understood as external indicators to guide strategic direction, rather than definitive measures of market performance or conversion.

To explain how international travel decisions form in digital environments, this report uses selected digital demand and tourism-system terms (e.g. awareness, influencer, friction, and search intent). These terms are defined in Annex B in plain language to ensure a shared understanding across policymakers, private sector actors, and development partners.

2. Global Digital Demand Signals

Tourism demand is not inherently digital. Travelers formed preferences, evaluated destinations, and booked trips long before the internet existed. Word-of-mouth, printed guidebooks, travel agents, and traditional media historically shaped awareness and decision-making.

However, in contemporary international tourism markets, a significant share of travel discovery, evaluation, and booking now occurs through digital channels. Search engines, review platforms, online travel agencies, media publications, and social content leave measurable traces of traveler behavior. These traces do not represent the entirety of tourism demand—but they provide observable indicators of how demand forms and progresses in global markets.

For analytical clarity, this report focuses on this digital layer of demand formation. It examines how often Timor-Leste is searched, how it is framed in international media, how visitors describe their experiences online, and whether search behavior suggests movement beyond curiosity toward structured trip planning.

To interpret these signals consistently, the report draws on established consumer decision theory (Engel, Blackwell & Miniard, 1995) and its adaptation to tourism in digital environments (Google, 2020; UNWTO, 2019). These frameworks describe a progression from initial awareness to evaluation, purchase, and post-visit sharing. In digital analytics tools such as SEMrush, similar stages are classified through search intent categories: informational, commercial, transactional, and navigational.

For analytical clarity, this report uses a five-stage digital travel journey model. These stages are also aligned with the four search intent categories used in digital analytics tools such as SEMrush (informational, commercial, transactional, navigational), which provide a technical lens for identifying where travelers are in the decision process.

Together, these frameworks help interpret where Timor-Leste is visible, where interest progresses, and where it slows.



Table 2A - The Digital Travel Journey Framework

Stage	Awareness (Dreaming)	Researching (Evaluation & Planning)	Booking	Experience	Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)
Traveler Actions	Travelers first encounter the destination name. Inspiration begins, often without a defined timeline or concrete plan.	Travelers evaluate whether the destination fits their interests, expectations, logistics, and budget. They compare options and begin structuring the trip.	Travelers commit financially through flights, accommodation, or tour reservations.	Travelers engage with the destination on the ground, interacting with services, infrastructure, communities, and activities.	After travel, visitors publicly share experiences through reviews, ratings, and social content, influencing new travelers entering earlier stages.
Typical Digital Signals	- International media coverage - Influencer blogs or videos - General search queries (e.g., “Where is Timor-Leste?”) - Google Trends spikes	- “Things to do in Timor-Leste” searches - Diving and marine research - Reading Booking.com, Tripadvisor, and Google reviews - Comparisons with regional destinations	- “Timor-Leste itinerary” searches - Hotel and accommodation searches - Flight and visa searches - OTA reservations - Direct hotel bookings - International tour operator packages	- Online reviews describing service quality - Ratings of accommodation, food, transport, and tours - Social media posts during travel	- Leaving reviews on experiences and accommodations - Travel blogs and long-form reflections - Social media posts and destination tagging
Alignment with Search Intent	Informational	Informational + Commercial	Commercial + Transactional	Limited direct search signal; primarily observed through reviews and social content	Informational (for future audiences) + Navigational

Each stage produces different types of digital signals. Media exposure and general search queries indicate awareness. Activity-based searches and review reading suggest consideration. Itinerary and accommodation searches signal planning depth. Booking-platform activity reflects conversion. Online reviews and social posts influence future travelers entering the journey.

This structure does not replace traditional tourism statistics such as arrivals or expenditure. Rather, it helps interpret *where* potential travelers appear to be positioned before travel occurs.

For destinations such as Timor-Leste, where visitor volumes remain relatively modest but niche interest is visible, understanding progression between stages is critical. A destination may generate awareness without consistently translating that awareness into structured planning behavior. Conversely, strong on-ground experience may generate positive advocacy without sufficient upstream visibility.

This section examines Global Visibility & Demand Signals through this digital lens. It analyzes search trends, seasonal interest, and comparative positioning to assess how international audiences currently engage with Timor-Leste—and whether observable digital behavior suggests early-stage curiosity or deeper planning intent.

2.1 Global Visibility & Search Trends

To interpret how international interest in Timor-Leste forms and progresses, this section applies the Five-Stage Digital Travel Journey Framework introduced above: Awareness (Dreaming), Researching (Evaluation & Planning), Booking, Experience, and Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy).

This section focuses primarily on the first two stages — Awareness and Researching — where digital demand signals are most observable through search behavior, keyword intent, and comparative visibility.

At the Awareness stage, travelers encounter the destination name, search for orientation information, and respond to media exposure. At the Researching stage, interest deepens into evaluation behaviors such as itinerary searches, accommodation comparisons, and activity-specific planning.

By distinguishing between these stages, this section assesses not only whether Timor-Leste is visible online, but whether digital interest progresses beyond curiosity into structured trip consideration.

This assessment takes three complementary lenses to capture these early signals.

- **Google Trends** is used to observe relative awareness, stability, and seasonality over time, indicating whether Timor-Leste appears in global travel consciousness and how that visibility evolves compared to peer destinations.
- **Search engine keyword data**, drawn from SEMrush (a tool that assists search engine performance, keyword research, and other digital marketing channels), provides greater resolution on how Timor-Leste is searched for. This helps distinguish between general awareness, tourism-related interest, and planning-stage intent.
- Finally, **comparative analysis against structurally similar destinations** anchors interpretation in a realistic decision space, ensuring that findings reflect relative performance rather than absolute scale.

Taken together, these signals reveal whether Timor-Leste is discoverable in travel-relevant contexts, whether tourism language appears early or late in the search journey, and whether observed interest shows signs of progression from curiosity toward consideration.

This approach establishes an evidence-based baseline for understanding where digital visibility supports demand formation and where the demand funnel weakens before planning or conversion can occur.

2.2 Seasonal Patterns & Market Interest

This section examines top-of-funnel awareness for Timor-Leste using Google Trends as a proxy for global travel-related interest. Google Trends does not measure or show absolute search volume. Instead, it reports indexed interest on a relative scale from 0 to 100, where 100 represents the peak search interest for a given topic within the selected time frame, geography, and comparison set.

As a result, values are context-dependent and should be interpreted comparatively rather than as standalone indicators of demand.

In this assessment, Google Trends is used to evaluate relative visibility, stability, and seasonality, not market size. The tool is valuable for identifying whether a destination is consistently present in global search behavior, whether interest compounds or dissipates over time, and how awareness compares to structurally similar destinations competing within the same low-volume decision space.

Searches were analyzed at the topic level where available, filtered to the Travel category, and observed over a five-year period to capture medium-term dynamics rather than short-term fluctuations.

Figure 2.2A: Global visibility in regional context

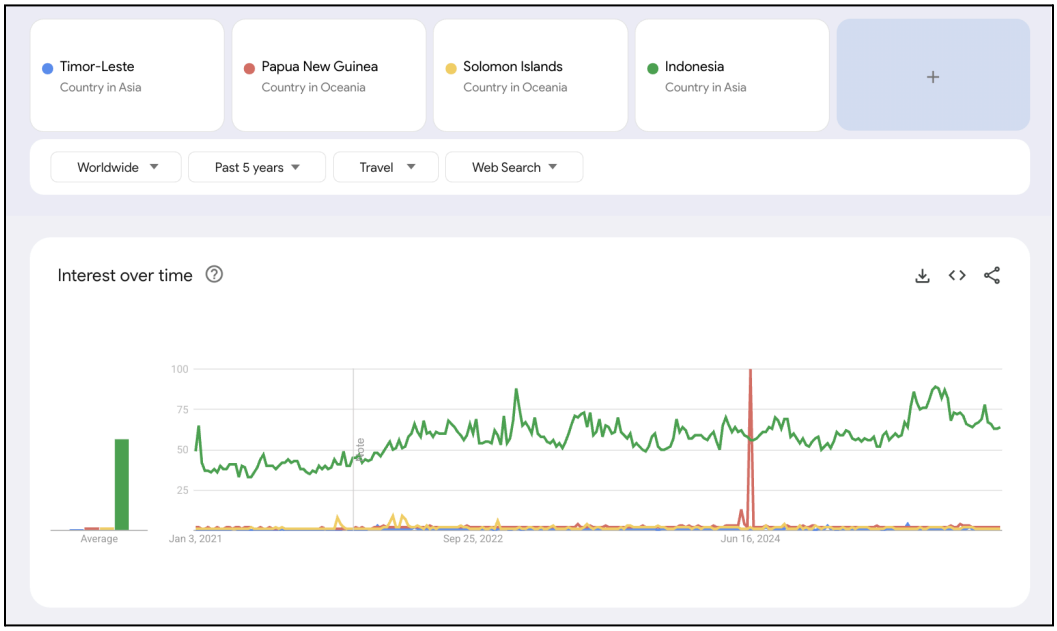


Figure 2.2A compares global travel-related search interest for Timor-Leste against selected regional destinations, including Papua New Guinea, Solomon Islands, and Indonesia. A brief spike is visible for Papua New Guinea in mid-2024. Given its short duration and rapid return to baseline, this peak is consistent with a short-term attention event rather than a sustained change in travel-related visibility.

At a global level, Indonesia dominates search interest at a scale that is not directly comparable to the other destinations. Its inclusion serves as an upper-bound reference, illustrating the magnitude of the regional awareness gap rather than representing a direct competitive benchmark. Timor-Leste, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands cluster close to the baseline, indicating that all three operate within a low-awareness segment of the global travel market.

This peer-level view reveals clearer differentiation: Timor-Leste registers at approximately half the indexed search interest of Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands. While values remain low across all three non-Indonesia destinations, the relative gap suggests that Timor-Leste underperforms even within its immediate peer group in terms of baseline global visibility.

The issue is not total invisibility, but rather weaker relative presence in the same low-volume decision space occupied by comparable island and niche destinations.

Figure 2.2B: Timor-Leste search dynamics over time

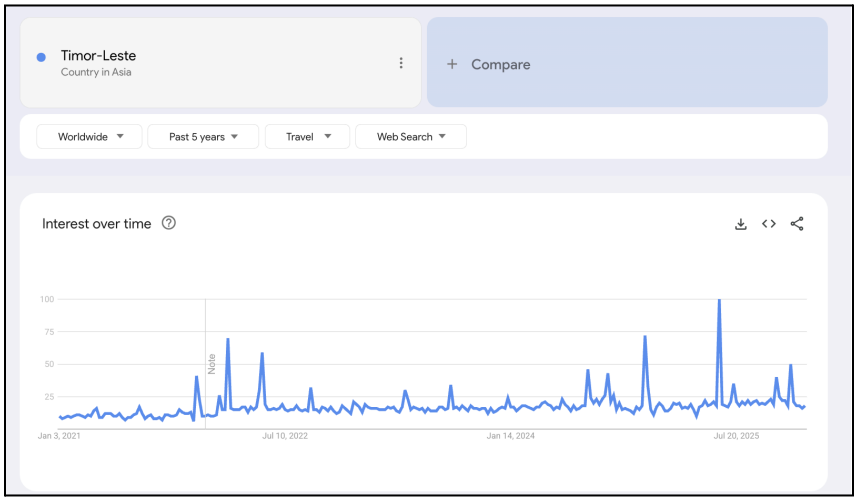


Figure 2.2B presents Timor-Leste search interest in isolation. Over the five-year period, the pattern is characterized by intermittent spikes rather than sustained or cyclical growth. While the baseline level of interest has increased modestly, demand remains volatile, with no clear or recurring seasonal pattern.

These spikes are not followed by lasting increases in baseline interest, suggesting that awareness is driven by episodic triggers—such as news coverage, policy events, or isolated media exposure—rather than by sustained destination marketing or travel planning behavior.

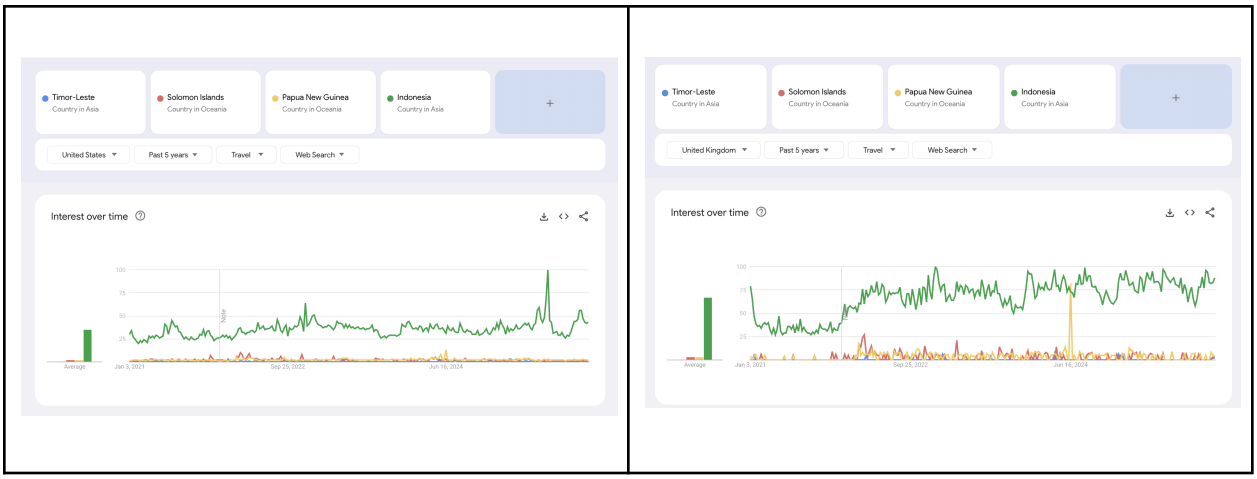
To assess where limited demand signals originate, search interest was examined across three potential source markets: Australia, the United States, and the United Kingdom.

Figure 2.2C: Australian Google Trend Interest



In Australia (Figure 2.2C), Timor-Leste exhibits its strongest and most consistent relative signal. However, even in this market, it remains below both Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands in indexed interest, indicating that geographic proximity alone has not translated into stronger relative consideration.

Figure 2.2D: United States & United Kingdom Google Trends Interest



In the United States and the United Kingdom (Figures 2.1D, left and right), search interest for all three small destinations remains low and irregular. Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands display slightly more frequent episodic spikes, while Timor-Leste maintains a flatter and lower baseline. Across both markets, there is no evidence of sustained or seasonally recurring demand for Timor-Leste as a travel destination.

Taken together, Google Trends data indicates that Timor-Leste maintains detectable but fragile global awareness. Relative to comparable destinations, it underperforms in search interest, and observed demand is episodic rather than compounding. Australia emerges as the most meaningful source market, though even there, Timor-Leste does not outperform peers.

These patterns suggest that the primary constraint is not the absence of interest, but the lack of digital and narrative structures that translate awareness into consideration. In practice, this includes content that introduces Timor-Leste compellingly but offers little guidance on how a trip might be structured or planned, a pattern explored further in the media and influencer analysis.

2.3 Global Search Interest & Seasonality

The previous section used Google Trends to understand when interest in Timor-Leste rises and falls across markets. This provides a high-level view of awareness and information-seeking behavior over time, but it does not indicate what happens once people begin searching in more detail.

This section shifts from general interest to specific searches to see what people search for related to the destination, with what frequency, and how Timor-Leste's official tourism website appears when travel-related searches are made.

To assess this, the analysis uses data from SEMrush, a search intelligence platform that estimates keyword demand, ranking positions, and organic visibility across markets. Rather than reporting exact search volumes or traffic, SEMrush provides modeled estimates based on observed rankings, historical performance, and typical click-through behavior. These estimates are used here to compare relative visibility across markets and content types.

The value of this data lies in its ability to distinguish between general awareness queries and tourism-relevant planning queries, and to assess whether official destination content is positioned to capture that intent.

The analysis focuses on search queries where Timor-Leste's official tourism website (timorleste.tl) appears in results for tourism-related searches. This reflects a practical assumption: when people search for travel-related information—such as things to do, places to stay, or how to plan a trip—the official destination website should appear as a reliable source.

Whether the official site does or does not appear in these searches provides a useful indicator of how well Timor-Leste is positioned once initial interest turns into more concrete information-seeking.

Rather than treating all organic search activity as tourism demand, the assessment concentrates on search types most closely related to travel planning and examines how visible the official site is across key source markets.

Market Selection for Domain-Level Analysis

To avoid over-interpreting very small or fragmented datasets, this analysis focuses on markets where Timor-Leste's official tourism website shows a minimum level of organic search visibility. Specifically, markets were included if the official domain ranks for at least 100 keywords in the SEMrush dataset.

Using this criterion, eight source markets were selected for comparison. Together, they represent a mix of:

- Higher-volume source markets, where travel-related search behavior is sufficiently deep and consistent to observe how interest progresses from discovery to planning
- Regionally or strategically relevant markets, where awareness exists but travel-related search signals are more fragmented or uneven

These markets provide sufficient depth to examine not just *whether* Timor-Leste is searched for, but *how* interest evolves across different stages of the visitor journey.

Table 2.3A: Organic Visibility of Official Tourism Website by Market (Keywords ≥100)

Source market	Ranking keywords	Estimated organic traffic per month	Primary site sections surfaced
United States	724	861	Destination overview; people & culture; safety and health guidance; selected experience pages
Australia	668	1.2K	People & culture; beach and experience inspiration; practical travel guidance (arrival, safety)
Philippines	347	1.0K	History and culture pages; destination overview content
Indonesia	208	358	Geographic and civic content, with notable exposure to Plan Your Trip pages (including shopping and services)
United Kingdom	165	519	Destination overview; geography and history pages
Singapore	136	412	Destination overview; safety and arrival guidance; selected experience pages
Canada	121	190	Destination overview; people & culture content
Brazil	104	183	Destination overview; geography-focused informational pages

Source: SEMrush Organic Research, timorleste.tl, desktop searches (January 2026)

European markets, including Portugal, do not appear in Table 2.2A because they do not meet the minimum threshold of ranking tourism-related keywords (≥100) for the official tourism website within the SEMrush dataset. While Portugal has strong historical and cultural ties to Timor-Leste, these ties do not currently translate into measurable search visibility for tourism-related queries. In practice, this means that most observed searches from Portugal are concentrated on general or informational terms with limited evidence of planning-stage behavior such as activities, accommodation, or travel logistics.

This pattern could be further validated through access to Google Search Console or Google Analytics, which would allow direct observation of referral traffic and branded search behavior by market.

While keyword volume and traffic provide a first indication of organic visibility by market, the type of page ranking offers additional insight into how far interest progresses beyond basic discovery. Across most source markets, top-ranking keywords primarily resolve to general destination pages, geography and history content, and people-and-culture sections of the official site. This pattern indicates that visibility is strongest at the awareness and orientation stage of the visitor journey.

In markets such as Australia and the United States, rankings extend slightly further into experience-related content—such as beaches, safety and health guidance, and "things to do"—suggesting early-stage planning behavior. However, even in these markets, organic visibility remains concentrated on a narrow set of informational pages, with limited penetration into itinerary-building, accommodation comparison, or activity-specific planning content.

By contrast, markets with lower overall keyword counts (such as Brazil, Canada, and several European countries) show an even stronger concentration on a small number of generic entry pages, reinforcing the view that awareness exists, but search behavior rarely advances into trip-shaping queries. Taken together, these patterns suggest that while Timor-Leste is discoverable across a range of markets, digital visibility is uneven in depth and remains skewed toward early-stage intent.

2.4 Keyword Demand & Search Intent

Search intent provides a practical proxy for understanding where potential travelers are positioned in the decision process, distinguishing between curiosity-driven discovery and planning-oriented behavior.

For the purposes of this analysis, keywords are grouped into four intent categories based on SEMrush's standard keyword intent classification, which is widely used in search and digital strategy to reflect different stages of the user decision journey. In this assessment, they are used to interpret how search interest in Timor-Leste progresses from early curiosity toward planning and booking behavior.

- **Informational intent** – curiosity and learning *(e.g. "Where is Timor-Leste?", "What is it like?")*
- **Commercial intent** – planning and comparison *(e.g. "best time to visit", "diving in Timor-Leste", "how to get there")*

- **Transactional intent** – booking-ready behavior *(e.g. “tours”, “hotels”, “dive resort”, “liveaboard”)*
- **Navigational intent** – brand validation and authority-seeking *(e.g. “official tourism site”, “Visit Timor-Leste”)*

A destination with strong digital visibility is not only searched for by name, but also through planning-oriented language, with queries that include modifiers related to duration, cost, timing, logistics, and specific experiences. The presence (or absence) of these queries provides insight into whether awareness is translating into meaningful travel consideration.

Table 2.4A: Regional Comparison of Keyword Intent

Type of Search	Timor-Leste	Papua New Guinea	Solomon Islands	Indonesia
Informational	600 (75.4%)	2,900 (75.9%)	666 (71.6%)	3,100 (71.6%)
Navigational	37 (4.6%)	249 (6.6%)	53 (5.7%)	196 (4.4%)
Commercial	124 (15.6%)	479 (12.7%)	150 (16.1%)	1,000 (22.8%)
Transactional	35 (4.1%)	181 (4.8%)	61 (6.6%)	209 (4.7%)

Across all markets analyzed, informational queries dominate search demand, accounting for approximately 70–80% of total keyword volume. These queries reflect early-stage curiosity and general knowledge-seeking rather than trip planning. Timor-Leste is in line with its regional competitors.

Transactional queries are rarer, though, when compared to other destinations. It’s normal that these types of searches might not always result in clicks to a destination’s official website, especially if online travel agencies or individual operators are better set up to serve the results. But the existence of these queries still registers as a search. Their near-absence reinforces the conclusion that these types of booking-related requests are still low for the destination.

Timor-Leste appears to show a relatively strong share of commercial intent (approximately 15.6%) compared to Papua New Guinea (12.7%). However, this should not be read as stronger demand performance. Timor-Leste’s intent distribution is derived from a much smaller keyword set (approximately 600–700 tracked keywords) than Papua New Guinea or Indonesia (both with ~3,000+ keywords). In smaller datasets, a limited number of tourism-related searches (e.g. hotels, tourism, diving) naturally account for a higher percentage of total demand.

While overall volume remains limited, the destination is already visible at key moments of consideration, providing a promising foundation for strengthening research-stage content and guiding users further into planning behavior.

Keyword Intent by Source Market and Planning Depth

While users frequently search for the destination name or basic country information, far fewer searches progress into questions about activities, accommodation, or how to organise a trip.

This pattern is visible in SEMrush intent distributions. In several European markets, including Portugal and Germany, over 90% of ranking keywords are classified as informational, with very limited commercial or planning-related intent. Overall keyword volumes in these markets are also low, which limits the ability to observe how interest develops beyond initial discovery.

By contrast, markets such as Australia and the United States show a broader and more developed search structure. In these markets, informational queries account for a share of ranking keywords that is more in line with Table 2.3A,, alongside a visible presence of experience-, accommodation-, and planning-related searches. This indicates movement beyond awareness into early consideration and, in some cases, planning-oriented research.

To better understand how interest actually progresses toward travel planning, this analysis therefore introduces simple search groupings that move beyond technical intent labels. These groupings focus on the practical question implied by the search—for example, what a visitor might do, where they might stay, or how they would organize a trip.

Australia is a particularly useful reference market for examining where interest advances and where it begins to stall. To explore this progression in more detail, Australian broad-match search data is examined below, with a focus on separating orientation-based searches from tourism-related demand and identifying how much interest progresses into explicit trip planning.

Table 2.4B: Timor-Leste Tourism-Related Keywords from Australia

Search grouping	What this represents	Example keywords (AU monthly volume)
Orientation & location searches	Geographic understanding and basic country awareness (non-tourism)	“timor leste map” (480) “timor leste on a map” (390) “where is timor leste” (320) “atauro island timor leste” (260) “timor leste country” (70)
Experiences & activities	What visitors might do and why they might visit	“timor leste tourism” (110) “diving in timor leste” (70) “timor leste diving” (70) “things to do in timor leste” (50) “places to visit in timor leste” (20)
Accommodation & stays	Where visitors might stay	“hotels in dili timor leste” (210) “timor leste hotels” (170) “timor leste accommodation” (140) “hotels in timor leste” (90)

Trip access & planning language	How to organize a visit using explicit travel-planning terms	“flights to timor leste” (170) “fly to timor leste” (140) “timor leste visa” (70) “how to get to timor leste” (20) “timor leste itinerary” (20) “travel to timor leste” (10)
— of which: itinerary-specific searches	Searches that indicate active trip structuring	“Timor-Leste itinerary”; duration-based variants

Source: SEMrush broad-match keywords, Australia. Volumes rounded. Jan. 2026

The figures shown in Table 2.3B reflect reportable search terms in the dataset. While additional long-tail tourism queries may exist, they do not register at sufficient volume to materially affect the overall pattern of demand.

In practical terms, most search activity related to Timor-Leste in Australia occurs before tourism planning begins, with orientation and location searches outweighing tourism-specific queries. Interest is strongest around experiences, followed by accommodation, with a sharp drop-off when searches move into explicit trip planning. True itinerary-level searches represent only a very small fraction of total demand.

This makes sense in the way a marketing funnel would work - more people will always be aware of a destination than actually think about a trip, and more people will think about a trip than will actually travel. The next step would be how to both increase the volume at the top of the funnel (e.g. overall awareness of Timor-Leste as a tourism destination) and to increase the conversion rate by helping potential travelers understand how to access the destination.

2.5 Planning Depth & Search Progression

To understand how search interest translates into meaningful travel consideration, two planning-oriented keyword clusters were examined across Timor-Leste, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands:

1. **Itinerary-related searches**, which indicate intent to structure a trip
2. **Diving-related searches**, which reflect experience-led planning around a core product

These clusters allow us to distinguish between surface-level interest and planning depth. This is not just how often a destination is searched, but how specifically travelers attempt to organize a visit.

Itinerary searches: similar headlines, different depth

At a headline level, itinerary-related demand appears broadly similar across destinations. In the United States and Australia, for example,, the generic keyword “[destination] itinerary” registers approximately

20 monthly searches for Timor-Leste, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands. On the surface, this suggests comparable levels of early planning interest.

However, examining long-tail variants, that is, keywords that have more qualifiers, reveals how far planning actually progresses.

For Timor-Leste, itinerary demand is almost entirely concentrated in this single generic term. There are no meaningful variants related to:

- trip length (e.g. “7 day”, “2 week”)
- routing or sequencing
- travel style or format

In other words, users signal curiosity about itineraries, but do not progress into questions about *how* a trip would actually work.

By contrast, both Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands exhibit broader and more developed itinerary structures. In addition to the core itinerary term, both destinations generate searches for variants such as:

- “2 week itinerary”
- “14 day itinerary”
- duration- or route-specific planning language

This difference is reflected in total global itinerary-related volume:

- **Papua New Guinea:** ~220 monthly searches
- **Timor-Leste:** ~130 monthly searches
- **Solomon Islands:** ~90 monthly searches

While the Solomon Islands has lower total volume than Timor-Leste, its demand is distributed across more specific planning queries, indicating deeper consideration despite a smaller overall search footprint.

Diving searches: depth amplifies the contrast

The difference becomes more pronounced when examining a specific experience category where all three destinations have recognized potential: diving.

For Timor-Leste, the core diving keyword (*“Timor-Leste diving”*) registers a global search volume of ~620, supported by a limited set of variants (14 total keywords). Papua New Guinea shows a stronger signal, with a global diving-related volume of ~1,200, supported by a broader range of variants (68 keywords), including liveaboards and comparative terms such as “best diving in Papua New Guinea.”

The Solomon Islands display the strongest planning depth of the three. Core diving keywords reach ~1,300 global searches, supported by 52 keyword variants and a combined long-tail volume of ~1,000, including phrasing such as “scuba diving,” “diving in,” and destination-specific activity searches.

Across both itinerary and diving examples, Timor-Leste shows early-stage interest but limited progression into detailed planning behavior. Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands, while still niche destinations, demonstrate more frequent movement from awareness into concrete trip design.

These examples illustrate why intent-stage segmentation is essential. Headline volumes alone obscure meaningful differences in traveler readiness.

This pattern suggests that Timor-Leste currently functions more as an idea or point of curiosity than as an actively evaluated travel option.

2.6 Comparator Benchmarking

Timor-Leste’s organic search demand is modest. However, this alone does not indicate underperformance. Comparable island destinations in the Pacific region also operate within relatively small global demand pools, particularly those that are remote, lightly developed, or positioned outside mass tourism circuits.

This comparison reveals that low absolute demand is normal, but demand structure is not uniform.

Table 2.6: Digital Visibility for Regional Tourism Websites

Metric (Approx.)	Timor-Leste	Papua New Guinea	Solomon Islands	Indonesia
Monthly organic traffic	~2,400	~15,000	~3–5,000	~150,000
Keyword count	~1.6k	~11k	~300	26k+
Informational share	Very high	High	High	Moderate
Commercial depth	Low	Moderate–high	Moderate	High
Itinerary variants	Minimal	Strong	Present	Extensive

Solomon Islands

At a peer level, Timor-Leste and the Solomon Islands show broadly similar overall visibility. Both destinations attract relatively small volumes of organic search traffic and remain largely informational in how they are discovered online.

However, the Solomon Islands demonstrate greater depth in planning-stage behavior. Search demand includes a wider range of itinerary-related queries, experience modifiers, and trip-length variations (e.g. multi-day itineraries), indicating that travelers are more frequently imagining structured trips rather than engaging only at a discovery level. This is even with the consumer-facing site (https://www.visitsolomons.com.sb/) still being outranked by the corporate website (https://tourismsolomons.com/) in most searches.

Papua New Guinea

Papua New Guinea provides an important reference point for what is achievable at moderate scale. While PNG is not a mass destination, it demonstrates significantly stronger research-stage signals across multiple themes.

Experience-led searches such as diving are not only higher in volume, but are accompanied by rich keyword clustering, including terms related to liveaboards, quality comparisons, and specific travel formats. Itinerary-related searches similarly show multiple variants, reflecting active trip construction by prospective travelers.

Importantly, this behavior emerges without exceptionally large traffic volumes. The PNG example demonstrates that meaningful planning demand can exist even within niche markets, provided that the destination is clearly framed and searchable as a travel experience rather than solely as a place.

Indonesia

Indonesia serves as an upper-bound reference for digital demand maturity. Its search profile is characterized by:

- Substantially higher overall traffic and keyword coverage
- A more balanced distribution across informational, commercial, and transactional intent
- Strong branded and navigational demand, indicating that official and semi-official digital touchpoints play an active role in trip planning

This comparison is intended to illustrate the end state of a mature destination ecosystem, where awareness, planning, and conversion-oriented behaviors coexist across the search journey.

2.7 What Digital Demand Signals Indicate

Taken together, the comparator analysis suggests that Timor-Leste's digital challenge is not one of scale alone, nor is it an outlier in terms of overall visibility for destinations of similar size and geography.

Instead, the distinguishing constraint lies in demand progression:

- Awareness-level interest exists

- Planning-stage behavior is weakly developed
- Official digital assets play a minimal role in guiding or capturing intent

Relative to its peers, Timor-Leste underperforms primarily in the middle of the funnel, where destinations transition from being discovered to being actively considered.

This positioning implies that future improvements in digital performance are likely to come from increasing awareness that is tied to tangible, planning-oriented behavior.

Across all measures examined—Google Trends, keyword demand, intent structure, and peer benchmarking—Timor-Leste demonstrates detectable but fragile global visibility. Awareness exists, particularly in Australia and to a lesser extent in long-haul markets such as the United States and United Kingdom, but it is episodic rather than cumulative.

Search interest is driven by intermittent spikes rather than sustained or seasonal patterns, indicating that visibility is influenced more by isolated media or contextual triggers than by ongoing destination-led demand formation. Relative to comparable destinations, Timor-Leste consistently underperforms on baseline search visibility, suggesting that the challenge is not absolute invisibility, but weaker presence within an already low-volume competitive space.

Experience-led curiosity—particularly around diving and nature—is evident, but this interest rarely deepens into itinerary design, duration planning, or comparative evaluation. Even where headline planning categories appear sizable, demand is largely driven by map, location, or access queries rather than by trip-structuring intent. Compared to Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands, Timor-Leste shows significantly less depth in long-tail planning behavior, reinforcing the conclusion that curiosity frequently stalls before active trip construction begins.

Taken together, these signals indicate that Timor-Leste currently functions online more as a destination to learn about than one to plan for. Importantly, this does not reflect a lack of experiential appeal, a finding that is supported by the following section analyzing visitor sentiment.

Official digital assets capture some planning-stage queries when they occur, but the overall planning ecosystem remains thin, limiting the conversion of awareness into sustained consideration.

This diagnostic establishes a clear baseline: future gains in digital performance will come not just from increasing broad awareness of the destination alone, but also by strengthening what's available in the research and planning part of the traveler journey and giving more clarity into how the experiences in-country are structured.

3. Visitor Experience & Online Sentiment

Having examined how Timor-Leste performs in the Awareness and Researching (Evaluation & Planning) stages of the digital journey, this section shifts focus to the downstream stages of Experience and Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy).

While search data reveals how interest forms, visitor reviews reveal how the destination performs once travelers arrive. Review platforms such as Booking.com, Tripadvisor, and Google Maps capture lived experiences and post-visit reflection, making them critical signals of the Experience and Sharing stages.

These stages are especially important for emerging destinations: positive experience strengthens advocacy and reinforces future awareness, while repeated friction can weaken progression earlier in the journey.

This section therefore examines how Timor-Leste is described after the visit has taken place, identifying strengths that reinforce demand and friction points that may suppress recommendation or repeat consideration.

3.1 Methodology

Sentiment analysis is used here as a diagnostic tool, not simply a measure of satisfaction. The objective is to identify recurring strengths, points of friction, and experience gaps that influence how Timor-Leste is remembered and talked about after a visit.

Findings are interpreted comparatively:

- across platforms (Booking.com, Tripadvisor, Google Reviews),
- across experience types (accommodation, food, activities, transport),
- and across comparator destinations.

This allows structural issues to be distinguished from platform-specific or audience-specific effects.

How sentiment is measured

The analysis uses a lexicon-based approach to evaluate emotional tone in visitor review text. Reviews are processed using *TextBlob*, a widely used natural language processing library suited to large-scale comparative analysis.

Each review is assigned:

- a **polarity score** (–1 to +1), indicating overall emotional tone; and
- a **subjectivity score** (0 to 1), indicating whether language is opinion-based or factual.

Polarity scores are grouped into positive, neutral, or negative categories using consistent thresholds across all platforms and destinations. These categories are used to compare patterns and trends, rather than to make absolute judgments about performance.

While star ratings are useful, they come with limitations. The biggest one for a destination is that these ratings are self-contained and difficult to interpret across a sector or across a destination. Text analysis of a larger set of reviews makes it possible to:

- Identify if a success or a shortcoming is related to one entity or if it's common across the sector or destination
- identify experiences that consistently exceed expectations, especially when compared to regional competitors
- detect issues that generate disproportionate frustration when they occur, ones that are more notable in the intensity of the language more than a simple 5-point scale

This approach helps pinpoint what actually needs fixing, versus what simply needs clearer expectation-setting.

3.1.1 Multi-Platform Data Integration

The sentiment analysis draws on visitor reviews from three major platforms—Booking.com, Tripadvisor, and Google Reviews—each of which captures a different part of the travel experience. Reviews span 2005-2026, with approximately half from 2020 onwards. This ensures the analysis is weighted toward current conditions while enabling identification of persistent destination characteristics versus emerging trends.

These platforms are deliberately combined because they serve different roles in the visitor journey:

- **Booking.com** reflects accommodation performance through verified, post-stay reviews, with a structured separation between "liked" and "disliked" feedback.
- **Tripadvisor** captures more reflective, experience-led evaluations of accommodation, restaurants, and attractions.
- **Google Reviews** surfaces short, immediate reactions to everyday services used by both locals and tourists, alongside reviews for traditional tourist services

Though Booking.com also allows ratings of activities and attractions, Timor-Leste, Solomon Islands, and Papua New Guinea do not show any active results, so the analysis was restrained to accommodations.

For each review, the following information is retained where available:

- publication date
- traveler type (e.g. solo, couple, family)
- category (accommodation, restaurant, attraction, activity)
- language

This approach allows platform differences to be examined explicitly rather than averaged away, and supports triangulation across platforms with different evaluation norms.

3.1.2 Language Detection and Translation Harmonization

The review dataset includes content in more than 20 languages. To ensure comparability across markets, all non-English reviews are translated into English prior to analysis.

Language detection is performed automatically. Non-English reviews are then translated using Google Translate via the *deep-translator* library. Both the original text and the translated version are retained, with metadata flags indicating original language and translation status. Translations are cached to ensure consistency across repeated analyses.

While translation reduces some linguistic nuance, this approach allows sentiment patterns to be compared systematically across languages and source markets. Where necessary, results are interpreted with cultural context in mind, particularly in cases where expression styles differ (for example, more restrained versus more expressive review language).

3.1.3 Theme-Based and Aspect-Level Sentiment Analysis

In addition to overall sentiment scores, the analysis examines sentiment at the theme and aspect level to understand which parts of the visitor experience most strongly shape perception.

Rather than treating each review as a single unit, keyword-based matching is used to isolate sentences that reference specific experiential dimensions, including:

- **Accommodation** (e.g. cleanliness, room quality, staff, comfort, value, amenities)
- **Food and beverage** (e.g. food quality, service, atmosphere, authenticity)
- **Attractions and activities** (e.g. diving and snorkeling, beaches, culture, nature, adventure)

Sentiment is calculated at the sentence level within these themes, rather than across the full review text. This makes it possible to separate overall satisfaction from specific points of friction or delight.

For example:

- a largely positive review that includes a clear complaint about Wi-Fi can be identified as a targeted infrastructure issue rather than general dissatisfaction;
- a neutral review that expresses strong enthusiasm for a particular activity can still signal a competitive strength.

This aspect-level approach supports:

- identification of consistent experiential strengths that function as differentiators

- detection of recurring friction points that may suppress recommendation or repeat consideration
- comparison of performance by theme across platforms and destinations

3.1.4 Interpretation and Limitations

Sentiment scores are interpreted directionally and comparatively, not as precise or absolute measures of satisfaction.

Review length, platform norms, cultural expression, and language all influence how sentiment is expressed. These factors are accounted for qualitatively when interpreting results.

To reduce the risk of over-interpretation, sentiment findings are triangulated with:

- platform-specific rating distributions
- review volume and frequency of thematic mentions
- cross-destination benchmarking

This ensures that conclusions reflect consistent patterns observed across data sources, rather than artifacts of language, platform design, or analytical technique.

3.2 Booking.com Insights

This section draws on visitor reviews of accommodation from Booking.com to understand how travelers evaluate their experiences in Timor-Leste at the accommodation stage of the journey. The analysis is presented in two parts. First, Booking.com reviews are examined to identify Timor-Leste-specific strengths and constraints as expressed by visitors across different traveler types.

Second, these findings are placed in comparative context through benchmarking against Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands. This comparison helps distinguish destination-specific accommodation issues from broader regional or structural patterns.

Unlike other review platforms, Booking.com reviews are submitted only by verified guests within three months after a completed stay. Reviews are structured to capture both positive and negative elements of the experience, resulting in feedback that is practical and service-oriented, closely tied to comfort, reliability, and value.

Booking.com also provides contextual metadata that supports deeper interpretation of sentiment patterns. Reviewers self-select a traveler type at the time of review, including solo travelers, couples, families, and groups.

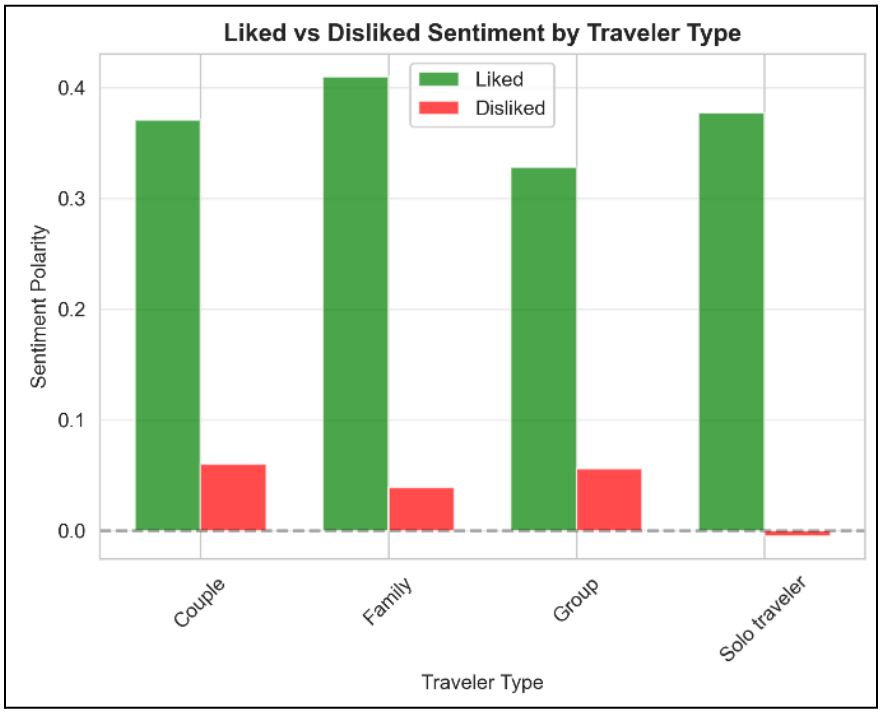
In this context, “group” refers to any non-solo, non-couple, non-family travel party (for example, friends or other shared travel arrangements), rather than exclusively to organized or agency-led group travel.

Where available, reviews also include information on length of stay. This allows the analysis to distinguish between experiences shaped by short visits and those associated with longer, more immersive stays. The platform's explicit separation of "liked" and "disliked" commentary further reduces ambiguity in interpretation, making it possible to isolate specific friction points even within generally positive reviews.

3.2.1 Booking.com – Timor-Leste: Traveler Type Performance

This analysis draws on 721 Booking.com reviews for Timor-Leste. Overall performance is strong, with high ratings observed across all traveler types.

Figure 3.2A: Liked vs Disliked Sentiment on Booking.com for Timor-Leste



Note: For readability, the chart's y-axis is constrained to –0.5 to +0.5, although the underlying sentiment scale ranges from –1.0 to +1.0.

Average sentiment across Booking.com reviews for Timor-Leste remains positive (0.294), and the comparison between "liked" and "disliked" commentary shows a strong positive skew. Sentiment associated with positive remarks is high (0.372). Sentiment in "disliked" commentary is slightly above neutral (0.024), which may appear counterintuitive at first glance.

This result reflects how sentiment analysis works. The model measures the emotional tone of language, not the evaluative context of the field in which the text appears. On Booking.com, travelers frequently express dissatisfaction in neutral, factual, or polite terms rather than emotionally charged language.

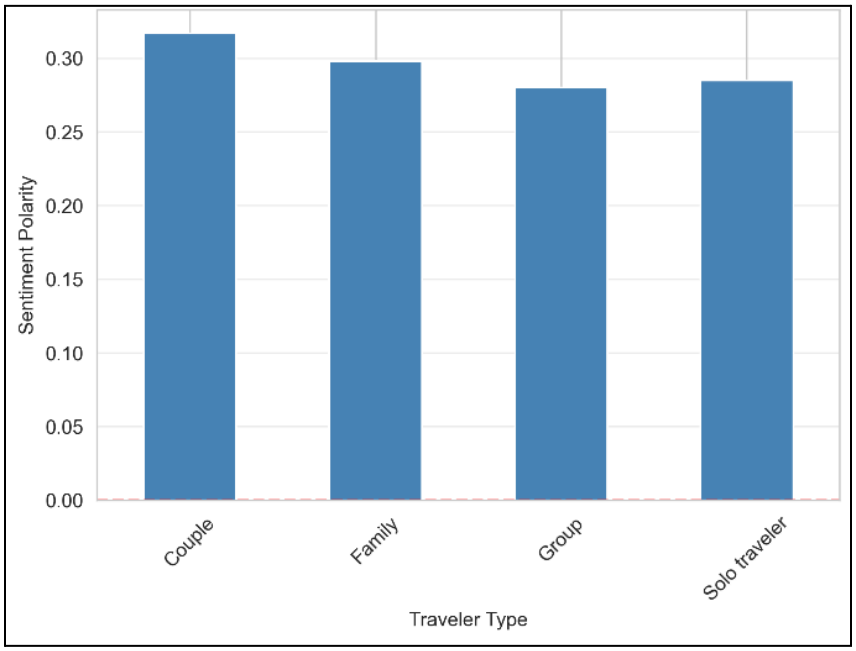
Statements such as “towels, bedsheets, and pillows,” “no meals apart from breakfast,” or “limited outdoor space” register as neutral because they describe issues without strong affect. Even constructive suggestions—such as “the breakfast menu could be expanded a little”—can score slightly positive despite appearing in the “disliked” field.

As a result, average sentiment alone understates dissatisfaction. More insight is gained by examining outliers and theme frequency, which reveal clear pain points by traveler type:

- **Couples** most often express dissatisfaction related to food quality and service (45.5% of negative mentions)
- **Families** are particularly sensitive to room facilities and comfort (80% of negative mentions)
- **Groups** focus primarily on connectivity and facilities in equal measure
- **Solo travelers** most frequently raise issues related to room quality and cleanliness, and account for the strongest negative outliers in the dataset

Dissatisfaction patterns are better captured through thematic concentration and extreme negative cases. The chart highlights that while most complaints are expressed calmly, specific service and facility failures generate genuinely critical feedback when they occur.

Figure 3.2B: Sentiment by Traveler Type on Booking.com for Timor-Leste



Differences by traveler type provide additional insight, as seen in Figure 3.2B.

- Couples rate Timor-Leste most favorably overall, combining the highest sentiment scores with strong average ratings, suggesting a good alignment between expectations, comfort, and experience.

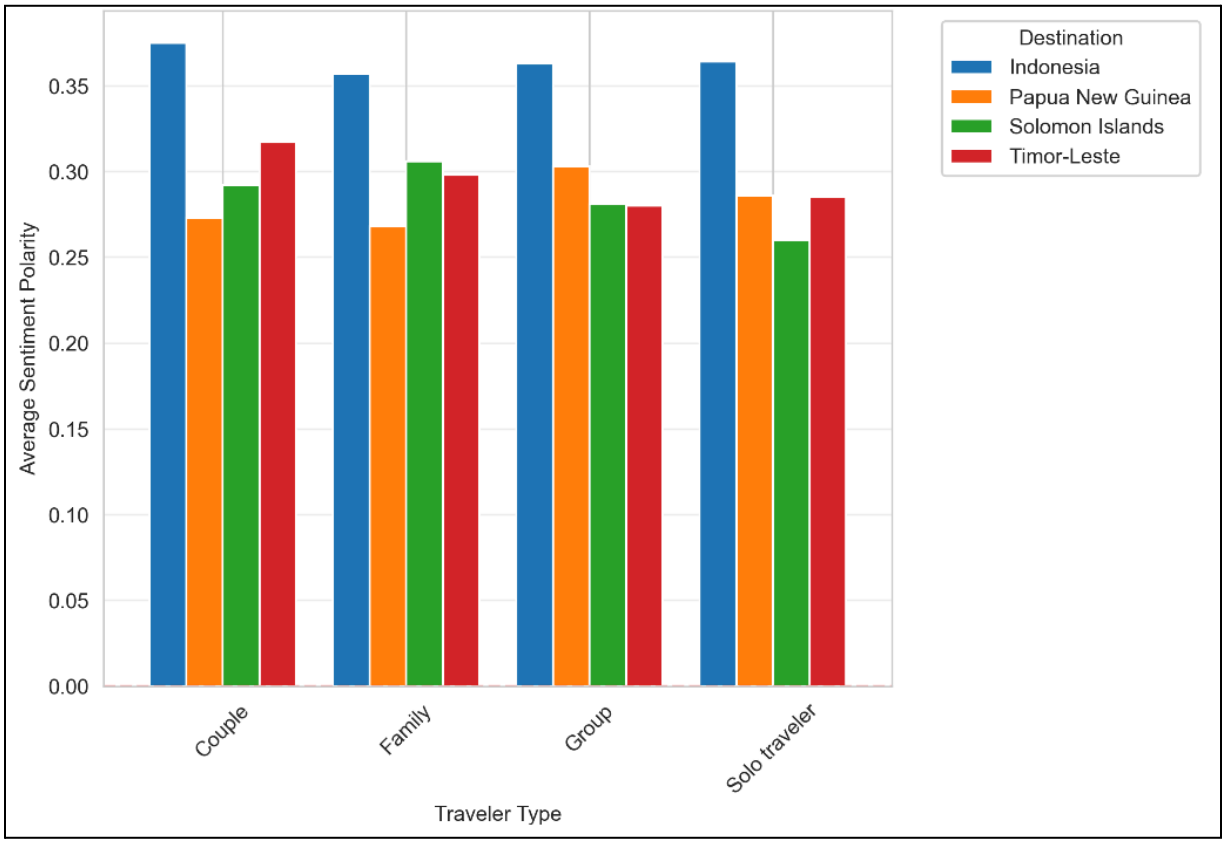
- Families award the highest average ratings despite slightly lower sentiment scores, suggesting satisfaction with outcomes alongside greater sensitivity to practical constraints.
- Group travelers exhibit solid but more moderate sentiment, consistent with higher logistical complexity and shared tolerance thresholds.

Taken together, these findings indicate that Timor-Leste performs well across all traveler segments, with no evidence of systemic dissatisfaction. Where sentiment is moderated, this appears to reflect contextual or logistical frictions—such as access or infrastructure—rather than deficiencies in the core visitor experience itself.

3.2.2 Booking.com – Regional Comparison by Traveler Type

To give more context to Timor-Leste's performance, traveler-type sentiment and ratings were compared across four destinations—Timor-Leste, Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands—using accommodation reviews from Booking.com. This comparison focuses on how visitors evaluate lodging experiences, including comfort, service, and value, and helps distinguish accommodation-related constraints from broader destination-level factors.

Figure 3.2C: Sentiment Polarity on Booking.com - Regional Analysis



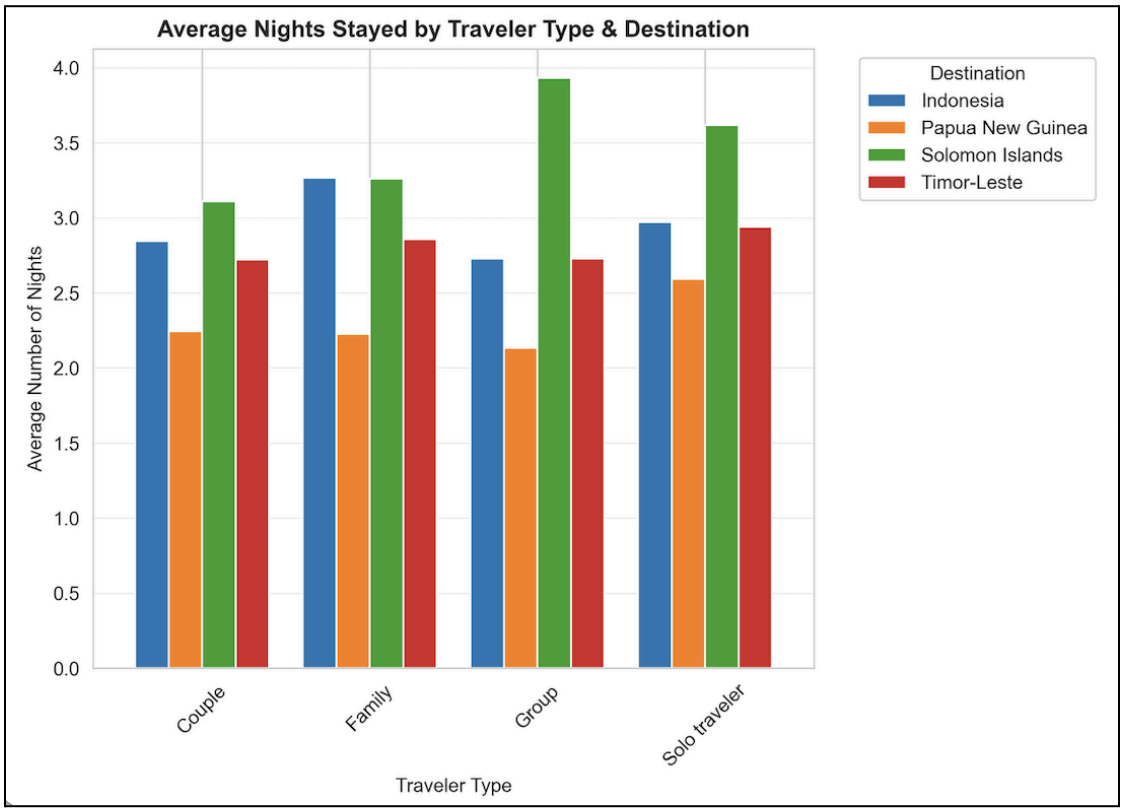
Within this accommodation-focused context, Indonesia consistently outperforms all other destinations across traveler types, recording the highest sentiment scores. Performance is particularly strong among

group travelers, where Indonesia achieves both the highest sentiment and the highest ratings observed in the dataset. These results position Indonesia as a mature, high-comfort benchmark in accommodation performance, reflecting scale, consistency, and long-established service standards rather than a directly comparable emerging destination.

Relative to its peer destinations, Timor-Leste performs well in accommodation-related evaluations.

- **Couples**: Timor-Leste ranks second overall, with strong sentiment, outperforming both Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands.
- **Families**: Lower sentiment ratings among families, despite high overall ratings, likely reflects higher expectations around comfort and logistics rather than dissatisfaction with accommodation quality.
- **Solo travelers**: Timor-Leste's sentiment is comparable to Papua New Guinea and stronger than the Solomon Islands, indicating solid alignment with independent travelers.
- **Groups**: Performance is more moderate, ranking below Indonesia and Papua New Guinea but remaining close to the Solomon Islands. This suggests room for improvement in group-oriented accommodation experiences rather than systemic shortcomings.

Figure 3.2D: Average Nights Stayed by Traveler Type & Destination



Length-of-stay data provides an additional behavioral lens that reinforces these findings. In Timor-Leste, solo travelers record the longest average stays (approximately 2.9 nights), followed closely by families (2.86 nights), groups (2.73 nights), and couples (2.72 nights). This pattern indicates that Timor-Leste

resonates particularly well with independent and adaptable travelers, who are willing to stay longer despite modest accommodation infrastructure.

This stay pattern contrasts with regional peers. In the Solomon Islands, group travelers stay the longest (3.93 nights), while in Indonesia, families record the longest stays (3.27 nights), reflecting more developed, group- and family-oriented accommodation ecosystems. Papua New Guinea is the only comparator that mirrors Timor-Leste's pattern, with solo travelers also recording the longest stays (2.59 nights), suggesting that both destinations appeal to similar independent, adventure-oriented visitor profiles.

Taken together, sentiment and length-of-stay data suggest that Timor-Leste's accommodation offer aligns most strongly with couples, families, and solo travelers who are tolerant of variability and motivated by experience rather than standardized comfort.

The gap with Indonesia reflects differences in maturity and accessibility rather than deficiencies in accommodation quality. The divergence between strong ratings, slightly more cautious sentiment, and longer solo stays underscores the importance of expectation-setting and consistency, particularly as the destination seeks to broaden its appeal beyond highly adaptable traveler segments.

3.2.3 Theme Sentiment Analysis: Liked vs Disliked (Booking.com)

This analysis uses Booking.com's unique separation of "liked" and "disliked" text to distinguish between:

- what consistently delights visitors when expectations are met, and
- what triggers frustration when expectations are not met.

Importantly, the presence of "disliked" commentary does not always suggest overall dissatisfaction. Instead, it reveals the specific conditions under which otherwise positive experiences become fragile. Results are interpreted both for Timor-Leste individually and in comparison with Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands.

Liked themes: solid performance, lower emotional intensity

Across most "liked" themes, Timor-Leste records positive sentiment, though with less emotional intensity than Indonesia. This pattern is most visible in staff, location, room quality, and food. For example, staff sentiment in liked text reaches 0.419 in Timor-Leste, compared to 0.466 in Indonesia and 0.439 in the Solomon Islands. Similar gaps appear for location (0.406 vs. Indonesia's 0.482) and room quality (0.367 vs. Indonesia's 0.429).

This suggests that visitors describe experiences in Timor-Leste as good, helpful, or comfortable, rather than exceptional or "wow-factor." In practical terms, Timor-Leste reliably meets expectations, but does not yet generate the same level of emotional enthusiasm observed in more mature tourism markets.

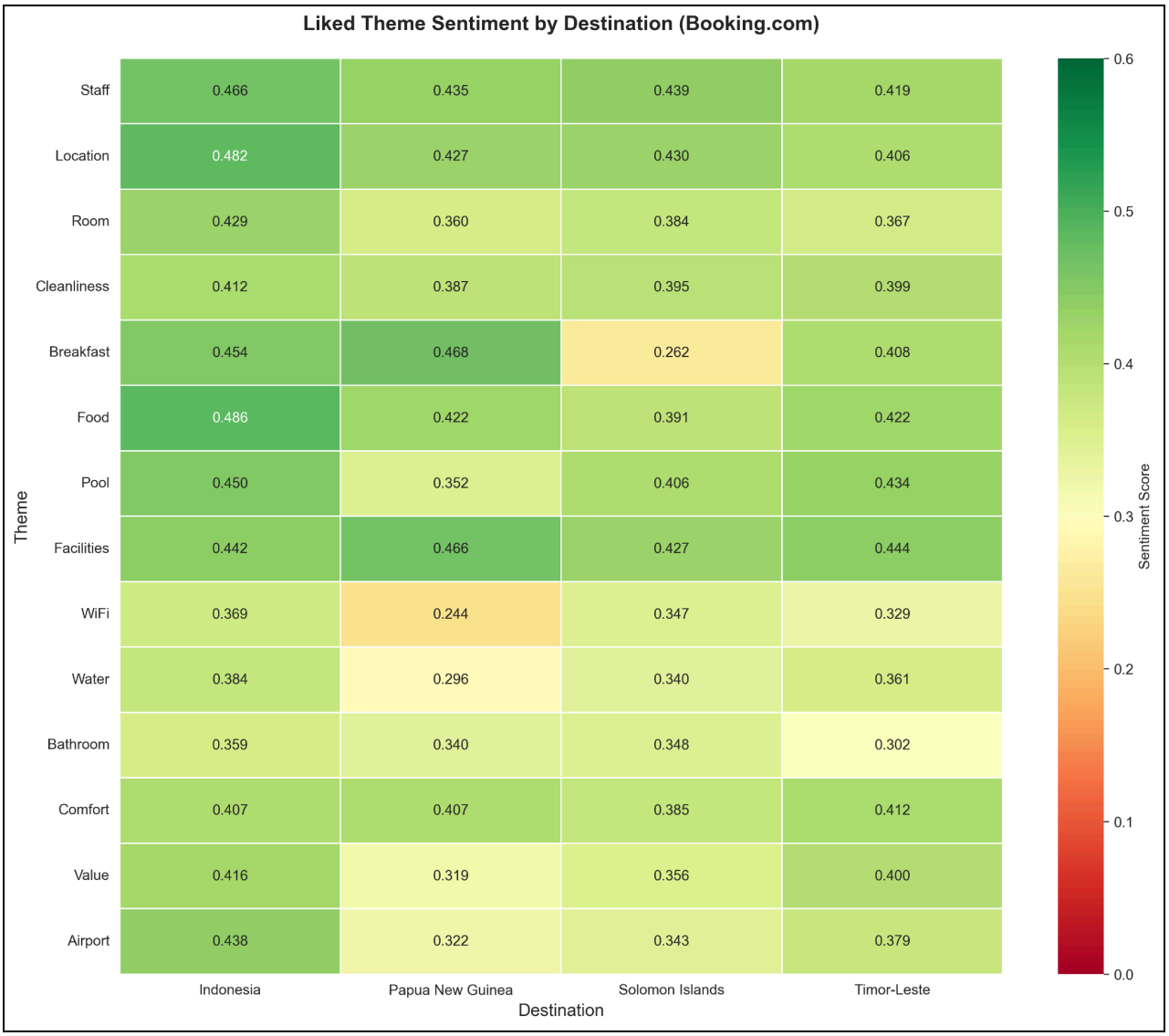
Competitive strengths: comfort and value are high-stakes assets

Several themes stand out where Timor-Leste performs at or near the top of the regional comparison. Comfort is the clearest example. Timor-Leste records the highest liked sentiment for comfort among all destinations analyzed, exceeding both Indonesia and Papua New Guinea. This aligns with earlier findings that families, in particular, rate Timor-Leste highly even when their sentiment language is more measured.

Pools also emerge as a relative strength, and perceptions of value are similarly competitive. Together, these results highlight an important dynamic: when core amenities are present and functioning, visitors respond very positively, even in a less developed destination context.

This confirms that comfort is not a “nice to have” for Timor-Leste—it is a central, high-stakes determinant of satisfaction.

Figure 3.2E: Liked Theme Sentiment by Destination from Booking.com



Disliked themes: where experience becomes fragile

The disliked-text analysis provides the clearest view of where Timor-Leste's visitor experience is most vulnerable.

The most significant weakness is Wi-Fi. Timor-Leste records the most negative Wi-Fi sentiment in the entire comparison, performing worse than Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands. Connectivity therefore represents a conversion-critical risk, particularly for families, solo travelers, and longer stays.

Figure 3.2F: Disliked Theme Sentiment by Destination from Booking.com

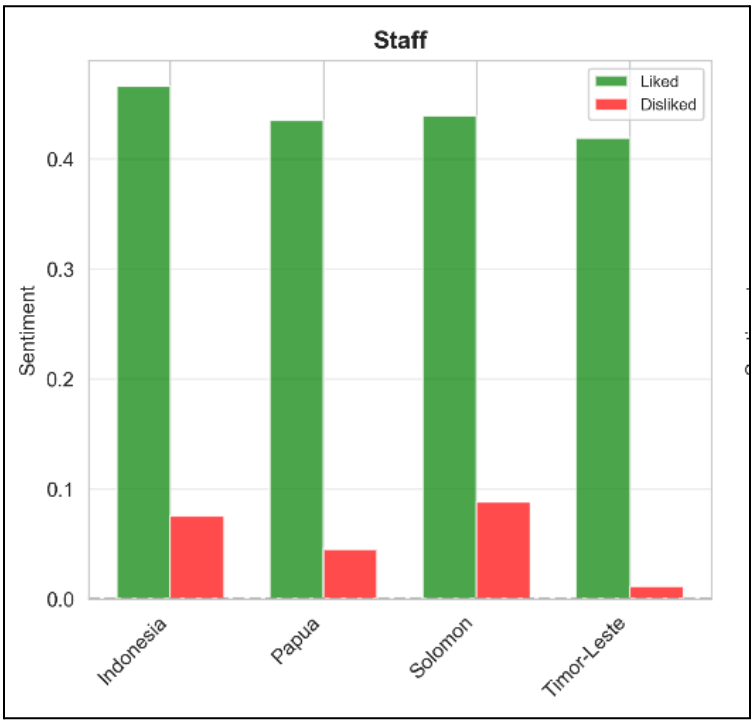


A second area of concern is comfort when expectations are not met. While comfort scores very highly in liked text, it becomes sharply negative when criticized. This "comfort paradox" indicates that visitors arrive with a clear baseline expectation. When that baseline is met, satisfaction is high; when it fails,

frustration is disproportionately strong. This reinforces the conclusion that comfort is a high-stakes factor rather than a marginal one.

Facilities show a similar pattern. Timor-Leste is the only destination where facilities-related complaints tip into negative sentiment, while other destinations remain neutral or positive even when facilities are criticized. This points to fragility rather than systemic failure: experiences are strong when functioning, but less resilient when basic services break down.

Figure 3.2G: Staff Theme Sentiment by Destination from Booking.com



Not all complaints work against Timor-Leste. Room-related complaints remain close to neutral in sentiment, making Timor-Leste the second-best performer after Indonesia. This indicates that while room issues are mentioned, they are typically described in factual or restrained terms rather than as sources of strong dissatisfaction.

Staff-related complaints follow a similar pattern. Even when problems are raised, sentiment remains relatively neutral, suggesting that staff interactions often help contain frustration and prevent issues from escalating into negative overall impressions.

Most notably, airport and transfer complaints are framed positively in Timor-Leste, the strongest result in the regional comparison. This suggests that visitors are either pleasantly surprised by the level of assistance at points of entry, or that staff support effectively compensates for infrastructural limitations.

Timor-Leste delivers positive experiences, particularly around comfort, service, and value, but those experiences are less resilient when basic infrastructure fails. The destination's weakness is not quality, but volatility. Satisfaction is high when things work, and sharply lower when they do not.

3.3 Tripadvisor Insights

Tripadvisor plays a distinct role in shaping destination perception. Compared to Booking.com, which is more accommodation-led, Tripadvisor can reveal how visitors feel more broadly about the destination after their trip, rather than confining the analysis to one portion. This makes Tripadvisor sentiment influential in shaping destination reputation, expectation-setting, and long-haul consideration.

As such, sentiment scores on Tripadvisor tend to be lower and more measured, even when ratings remain high. This first analysis takes 4,002 Tripadvisor reviews with text for Timor-Leste to understand how visitors describe their experiences when reflecting more holistically on the destination.

3.3.1 Sentiment by category: experience versus expression

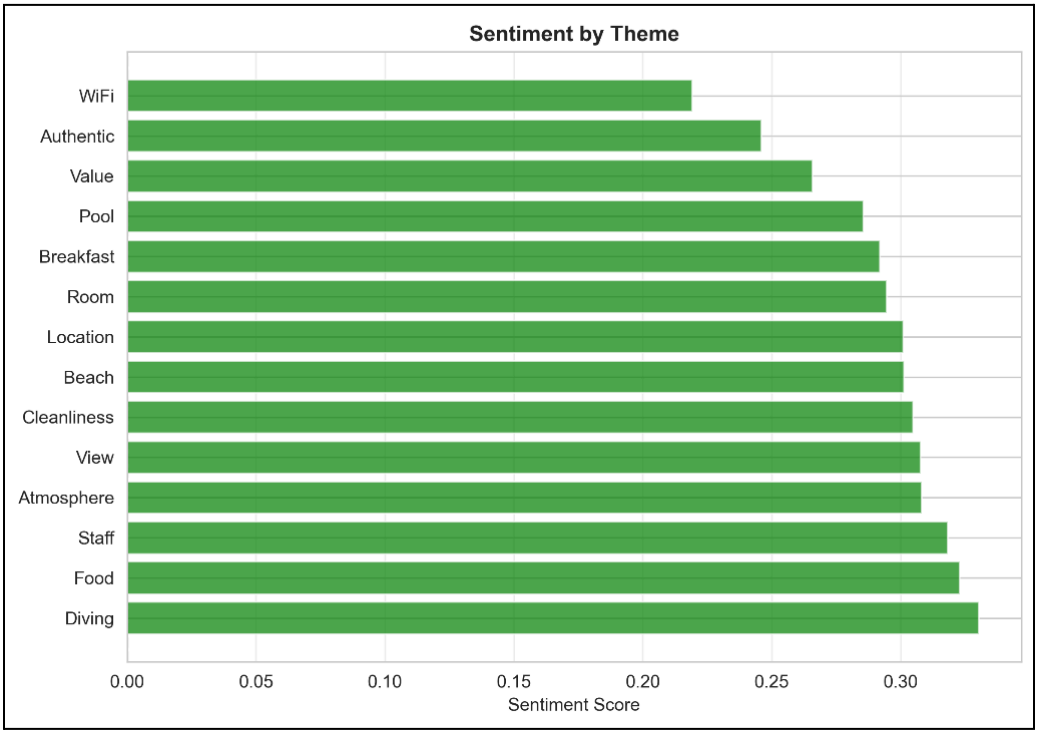
Across Tripadvisor categories, accommodation and restaurants record similar sentiment scores, indicating consistent satisfaction with core tourism services. Attractions stand out differently: while they receive the highest average ratings, they record the lowest sentiment scores among the three categories.

This pattern suggests a distinction between how experiences are valued and how they are described. Visitors clearly value attractions in Timor-Leste, but tend to describe them using neutral, observational language rather than emotional praise. Reviews frequently focus on factual elements—such as scenery, historical context, or the structure of activities—rather than expressions of excitement or enthusiasm.

Theme-level insights: what defines Timor-Leste on Tripadvisor

At the theme level, Tripadvisor highlights several clear strengths. Diving emerges as Timor-Leste's strongest experiential differentiator, recording both the highest sentiment and the highest rating across all themes. This confirms diving as a core asset not only in specialist discourse, but also in mainstream visitor reflection.

Figure 3.3A: Sentiment by Theme for Timor-Leste on Tripadvisor



Food, staff, views, atmosphere, and cleanliness form a strong upper tier, reinforcing earlier findings around hospitality, human interaction, and environmental appeal. Beach, location, room quality, and breakfast occupy a stable middle tier, while value and authenticity score lower in sentiment despite high ratings, suggesting appreciation expressed in pragmatic rather than emotional terms.

Wi-Fi again stands out as the weakest theme, with the lowest sentiment score and the lowest average rating. This directly corroborates the Booking.com disliked-text analysis, confirming connectivity as the most consistent friction point across platforms.

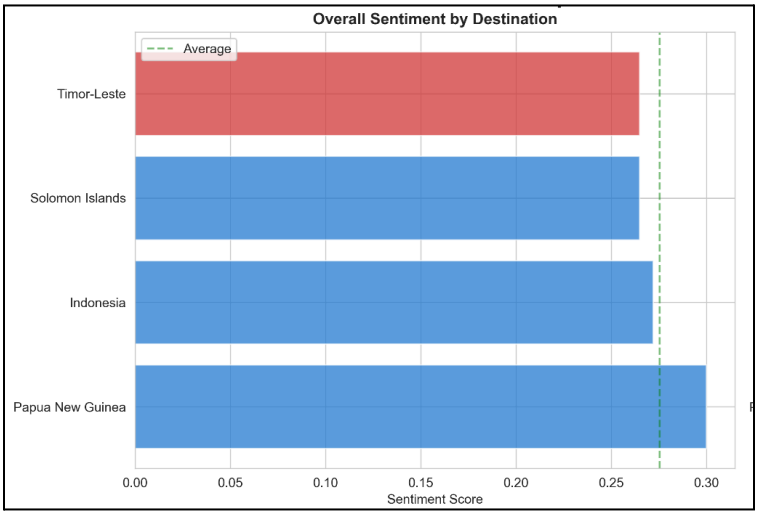
The Tripadvisor analysis reinforces three core conclusions.

- First, Timor-Leste delivers strong experiential value, particularly in diving, food, staff interaction, and natural settings.
- Second, visitor satisfaction is often expressed through ratings rather than emotional language, especially for attractions and authenticity, indicating a reflective rather than enthusiastic tone.
- Third, structural frictions persist across platforms and languages, making them highly visible to prospective travelers during research and planning.

3.3.2 Cross-Destination Competitive Positioning (Tripadvisor)

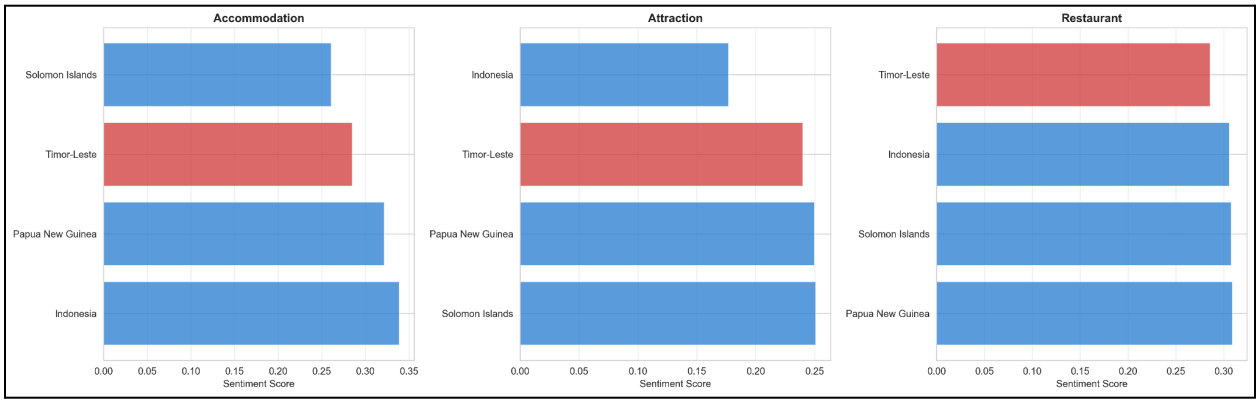
Based on analysis for Timor-Leste, the destination is tied with Solomon Islands for third of the peer destinations on overall sentiment.

Figure 3.3B: Sentiment by Destination on Tripadvisor



At the category level, Timor-Leste consistently ranks third across Accommodation, Restaurants, and Attractions, but with relatively narrow gaps separating it from leaders in most cases.

Figure 3.3C: Sentiment by Category Across Destinations on Tripadvisor



In **Accommodation**, Timor-Leste records a sentiment score behind Indonesia and Papua New Guinea, but ahead of the Solomon Islands. This suggests that while accommodation quality meets expectations for most visitors, it lacks the consistency and polish seen in Indonesia and PNG, particularly in room quality and facilities.

In **Attractions**, Timor-Leste is behind Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands. Despite this lower sentiment score, attractions in Timor-Leste receive the highest average ratings in earlier analyses,

reinforcing the idea that visitors rate attractions highly but describe them in practical, descriptive language rather than emotionally enthusiastic terms.

For **Restaurants**, Timor-Leste ranks fourth, closely trailing Indonesia and Papua New Guinea. The small differences here indicate that food experiences in Timor-Leste are generally positive but less memorable or less consistently executed than in competing destinations.

3.3.3 Priority Improvement Areas for Timor-Leste

The competitive gap analysis highlights several themes where Timor-Leste underperforms most clearly relative to regional leaders, particularly Indonesia.

Figure 3.3D: Theme Sentiment by Destination on Tripadvisor



Breakfast represents the single largest improvement opportunity. While Timor-Leste's breakfast sentiment score ranks second overall, Indonesia's leading score represents a 34% higher sentiment level. Review language suggests that variety, quality, and presentation—rather than availability—drive this gap.

Although operational in nature, breakfast functions as a visible signal of service standards for international travelers. Because it is experienced daily and by many guests, it strongly influences perceptions of professionalism, quality, and international readiness. It is also a simple point of comparison between hotels across destinations and service levels. The sentiment gap with Indonesia reflects differences in variety, presentation, and consistency rather than access, making breakfast a low-cost, high-impact opportunity for improving perceived competitiveness.

A similar pattern emerges for food, where Timor-Leste's sentiment score trails Indonesia by a significant margin. Given that food is one of the most frequently mentioned themes in reviews, this gap has an outsized impact on overall perception.

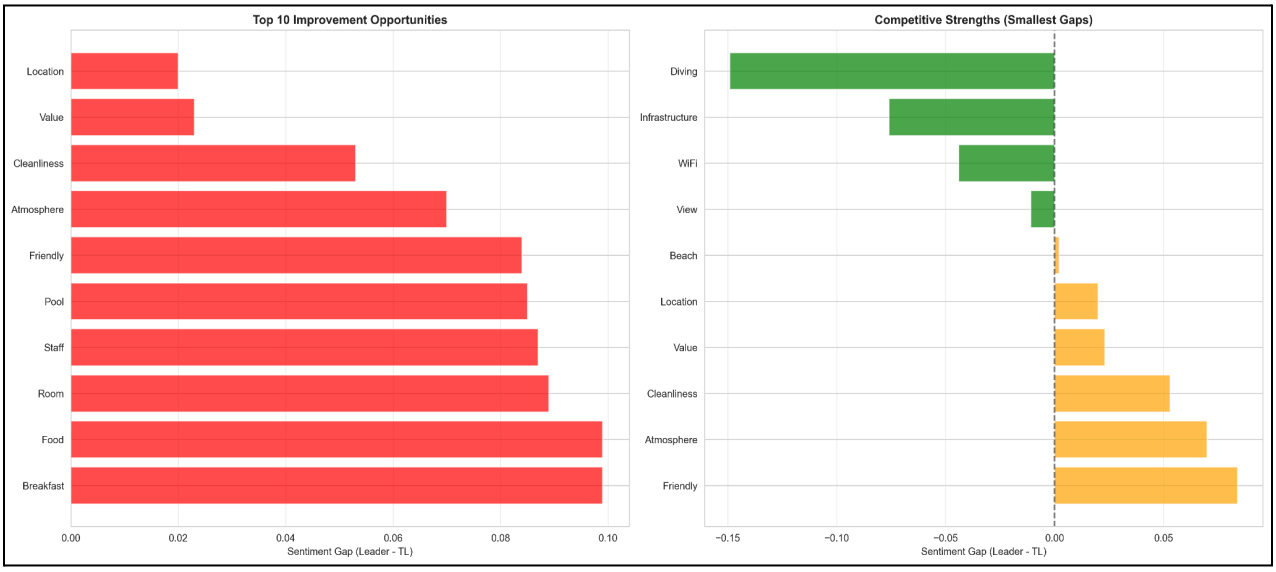
Room quality is another notable gap. Timor-Leste trails Indonesia, indicating that maintenance, comfort, and amenities lag behind regional expectations by roughly 30% in sentiment terms.

Despite being one of the most frequently praised elements in Timor-Leste reviews, staff sentiment also falls well behind Indonesia. This suggests that while staff are widely recognized as helpful and friendly, they are less often described as exceptional or memorable compared to service standards in Indonesia.

3.3.4 Areas of Competitive Advantage

Despite these gaps, Timor-Leste demonstrates leadership in several important themes, most notably diving. Timor-Leste ranks first among all destinations, outperforming Indonesia by a strong margin, firmly positioning diving as Timor-Leste's strongest experiential differentiator.

Figure 3.3E: Competitive Gap Analysis for Timor-Leste on Tripadvisor



Timor-Leste also leads in infrastructure sentiment, an unexpected but meaningful result. Visitor feedback suggests that roads, transport, and basic logistics are perceived more positively than regional

expectations would imply. This indicates that infrastructure performs better in practice than its reputation might suggest. This result may also reflect pre-visit expectation-setting. International media coverage and influencer content frequently emphasize accessibility, road conditions, and logistical challenges in Timor-Leste, which may lead first-time visitors to arrive with conservative expectations that are then exceeded in practice.

Views and natural scenery remain an area of strength. Timor-Leste closely matches—or slightly exceeds—Indonesia on sentiment in this theme, reinforcing its appeal as a visually striking, nature-led destination.

Together, these findings highlight that Timor-Leste's competitive advantages lie not only in niche experiences, but also in core elements that shape first impressions and memory formation.

3.3.5 Strategic Implications at the Experience Level

For Timor-Leste, the strategic path forward at the experience and service level is twofold.

First, close experience gaps in food, accommodation standards, and service consistency, particularly in high-frequency touchpoints such as breakfast, room quality, Wi-Fi reliability, and facilities. These areas drive disproportionate sentiment penalties when expectations are not met, yet are operationally feasible to improve without structural transformation.

Second, leverage areas of proven competitiveness, especially diving, natural scenery, transport reliability, and authentic interpersonal interaction. These are not emerging strengths. They are already validated assets across platforms and should anchor product development, quality standards, and positioning at the experience level.

3.4 Google Reviews Insights

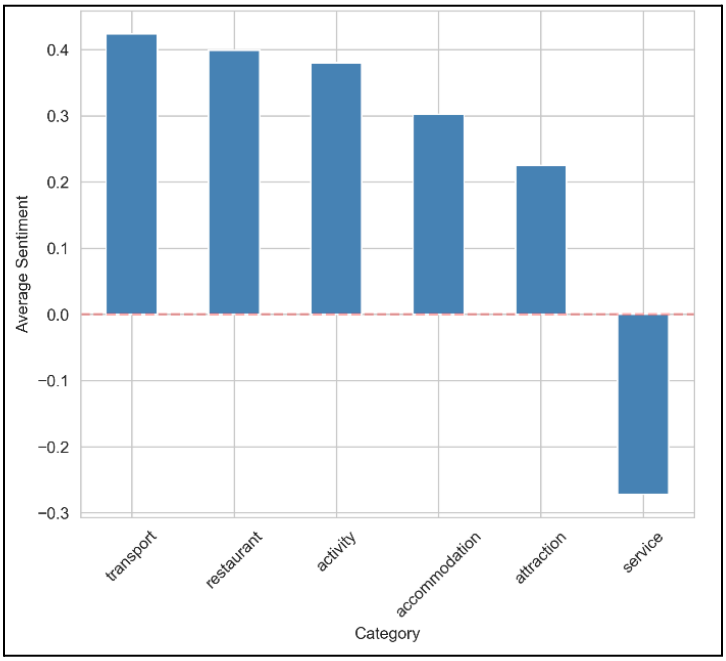
Google Reviews capture a different type of visitor feedback than Booking.com and Tripadvisor. While Booking.com focuses on accommodation experiences and Tripadvisor reflects more considered, narrative reviews, Google Maps reviews tend to be short, immediate, and written close to the moment of experience. As a result, it is particularly useful for understanding how visitors experience everyday services such as transport, casual dining, local attractions, and informal activities.

3.4.1 Google Maps Review Destination Focus

The Google Maps analysis is based on 598 reviews for Timor-Leste, most of which include written comments. Overall performance is strongly positive and exceeds sentiment levels observed on other platforms.

When compared with Booking.com and Tripadvisor, Google Maps records higher ratings and more positive sentiment. This suggests a strong baseline level of satisfaction in routine visitor interactions, particularly those encountered in daily movement, services, and informal experiences.

Figure 3.4A: Sentiment by Category for Timor-Leste on Google

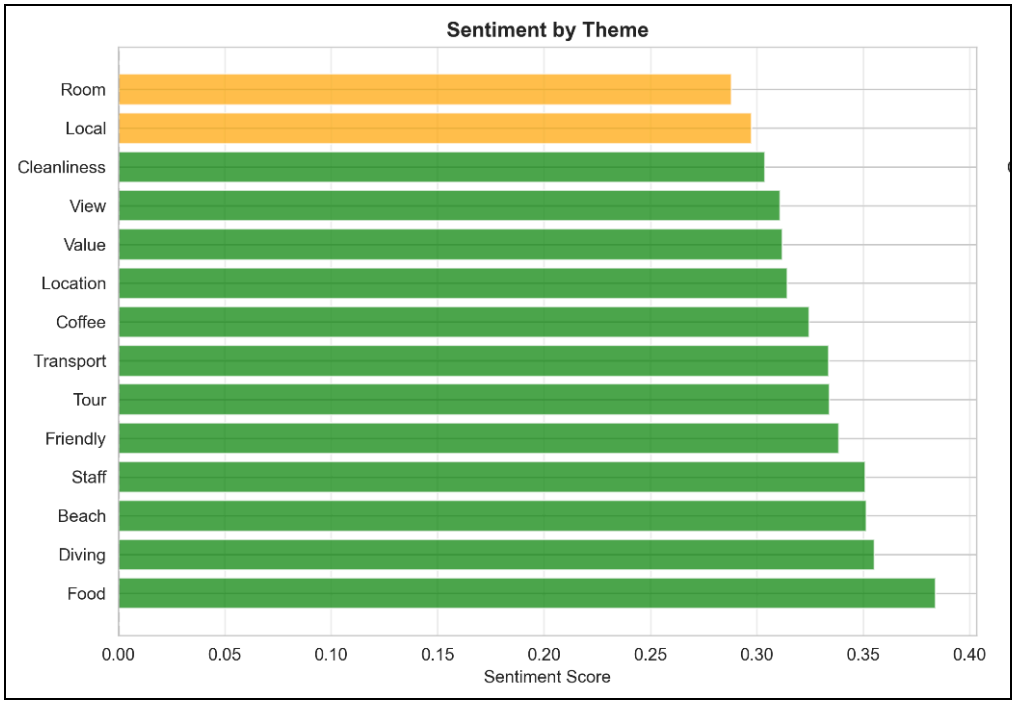


Category analysis helps distinguish where positive sentiment is driven by experiential strengths versus functional services.

- **Transport** emerges as the strongest category, reinforcing earlier findings that mobility and airport transfers are perceived more positively than expected for an emerging destination
- **Activities** perform well, confirming experiential offerings—particularly diving—as a core strength
- **Restaurants** also score strongly, aligning with food-related positivity across platforms
- **Accommodation** remains positive but performs below experiential categories
- **Attractions** show high ratings but more restrained language, a pattern also observed on Tripadvisor
- **Service** appears negative; however, this result is based on a single review and should not be interpreted as a structural issue

Taken together, these results reinforce a consistent pattern: experiences and human interaction outperform facilities, particularly where services are informal and interpersonal. Theme-level analysis highlights what visitors most frequently praise in everyday language. Food, diving, beaches, staff, and friendly service rank among the strongest themes, with food emerging as the most positively expressed theme overall. Themes such as room quality and local or authentic experiences score lower but remain positive, reflecting shorter and less descriptive commentary rather than dissatisfaction.

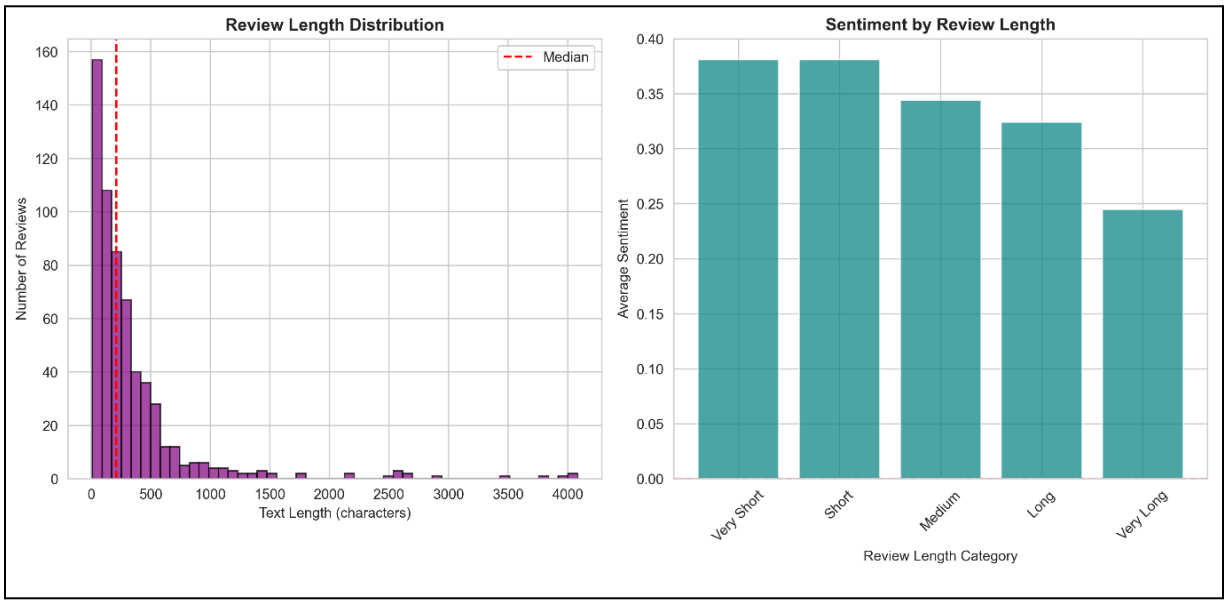
Figure 3.4B: Sentiment by Theme for Timor-Leste on Google



These results closely align with strengths identified on Booking.com and Tripadvisor, reinforcing the consistency of key experiential advantages across platforms.

Sentiment also varies systematically with review length. Very short and short reviews (under 100 characters) are the most positive, with average sentiment around 0.38. Sentiment gradually declines as reviews become longer and more detailed, reflecting more balanced and nuanced evaluation rather than worsening experience.

Figure 3.4C: Review Length and Tone for Timor-Leste on Google



This confirms that Google Maps captures quick expressions of satisfaction (“Great place,” “Amazing dive,” “Friendly staff”), while longer reviews introduce nuance and critique. As a result, Google Maps tends to skew optimistic, but in a consistent and interpretable way.

Language Profile

Google Maps reviews for Timor-Leste are overwhelmingly written in English (93.8%), with very limited representation from Portuguese, Japanese, or other languages.

This has two implications:

- Google Maps sentiment primarily reflects Anglophone visitor experience
- It does not surface the language-based perception gaps observed on Tripadvisor

Overall, Google Maps confirms that Timor-Leste performs well in informal, everyday visitor touchpoints, particularly:

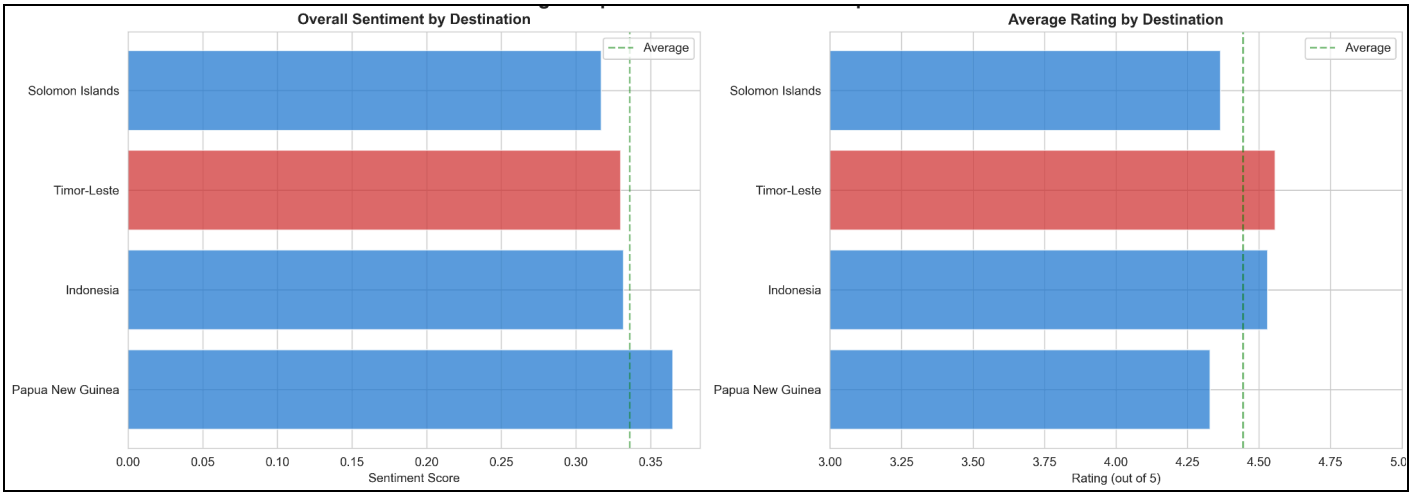
- activities and tours
- transport and logistics
- casual dining and coffee
- interpersonal interactions

While the platform’s limitations—shorter reviews, smaller volumes, and lack of traveler-type segmentation—mean it should not be used alone to diagnose deeper infrastructure or accommodation issues, it provides a high-confidence validation layer for overall visitor satisfaction.

3.4.2 Cross-Destination Visitor Sentiment Analysis - Google Maps

Across the four destinations analyzed via Google Maps—Timor-Leste, Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands—Timor-Leste ranks third in overall sentiment but first in average rating.

Figure 3.4D: Sentiment by Destination on Google



Papua New Guinea records the highest sentiment score, followed closely by Indonesia. Timor-Leste follows narrowly behind Indonesia. This divergence highlights an important dynamic: visitors consistently rate their experiences in Timor-Leste very highly, even when their written language is more restrained or brief.

At the category level, Timor-Leste demonstrates clear strengths in experiential and practical aspects of travel.

- **Activities:** Timor-Leste ranks first, outperforming all competitors. This category includes diving, tours, and hands-on experiences, reinforcing the destination's strength in experiential tourism and authenticity.
- **Transport:** Timor-Leste again ranks first, suggesting that mobility, taxis, and basic logistics are perceived as smoother than in competing destinations.
- **Restaurants:** Timor-Leste ranks second, just behind Indonesia and ahead of Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands, indicating a competitive casual dining scene in everyday reviews.

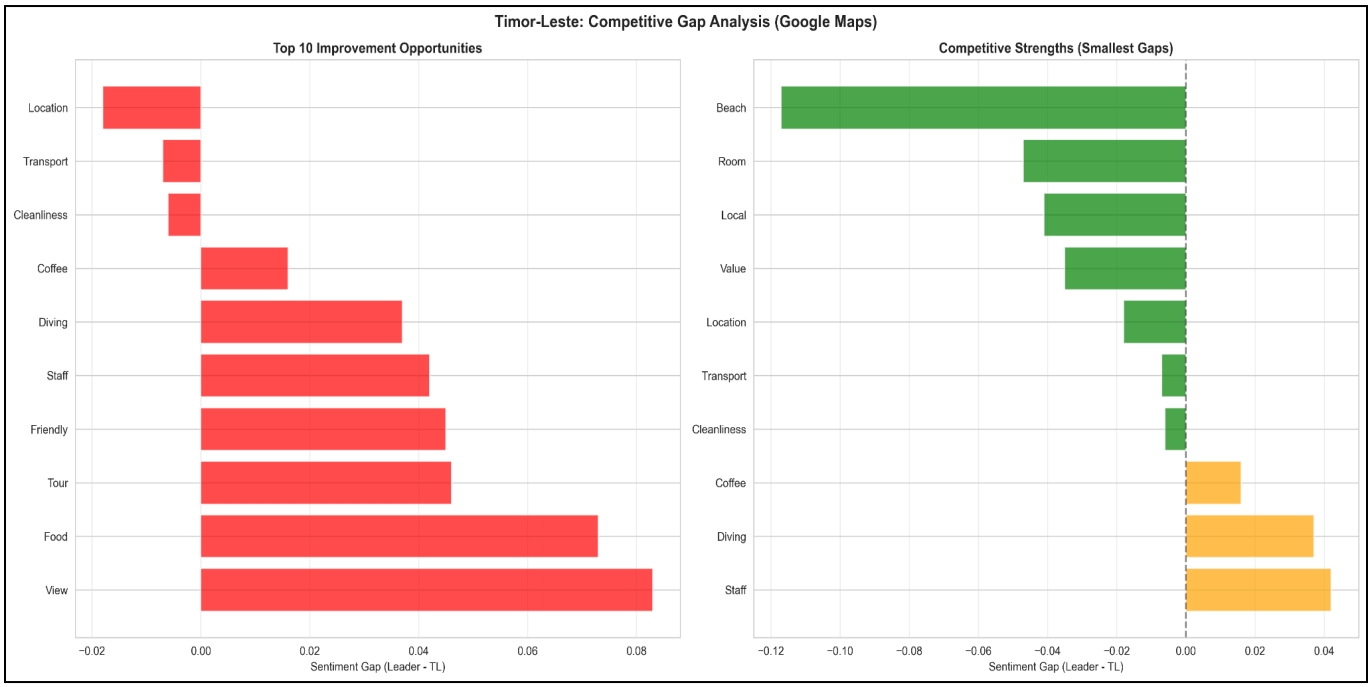
Accommodation and attractions present a more mixed picture. In accommodation, Timor-Leste ranks third, trailing Papua New Guinea and Indonesia. For attractions, Timor-Leste also ranks third, suggesting that while individual experiences are enjoyed, broader attraction narratives are less strongly articulated in short-form Google reviews.

A theme-by-theme comparison provides greater resolution on where Timor-Leste's advantages are most pronounced and where competitive gaps remain.

Timor-Leste demonstrates clear leadership in several experiential themes. Beach sentiment is the strongest differentiator, with Timor-Leste leading the region and outperforming Indonesia by a notable margin. Value perception also emerges as a clear strength, with Timor-Leste ranking first, reinforcing its positioning as a destination that delivers strong experiences relative to cost.

Themes related to transport, cleanliness, and local or authentic experiences show leadership or near-parity with Indonesia, indicating that day-to-day comfort and authenticity resonate strongly with Google Maps reviewers.

Figure 3.4E: Competitive Gap Analysis for Timor-Leste on Google



The largest competitive gaps appear in views, food, tours, friendliness, and staff. While Timor-Leste's scores in these themes remain positive in absolute terms, Indonesia consistently elicits more enthusiastic language. The gap in view sentiment is particularly notable: despite Timor-Leste's natural beauty, Indonesia scores significantly higher, suggesting differences in access, presentation, or how scenery is framed and experienced. Smaller but persistent gaps in food and tour-related themes point to opportunities around consistency, service polish, and storytelling rather than fundamental quality.

3.5 Cross-Platform Experience Patterns

Across Booking.com, Tripadvisor, and Google Maps, Timor-Leste receives consistently strong overall feedback, yet each platform illuminates a different "slice" of the visitor experience:

- **Tripadvisor** captures the broadest, most reflective destination evaluation
- **Booking.com** isolates accommodation performance
- **Google Maps** provides a more practical, everyday lens that blends tourist and local perspectives and expands beyond tourism-only categories (e.g., transport, services, coffee, casual experiences).

Read together, these sources describe different depths of evaluation and different parts of the tourism system, which is why sentiment varies by platform.

- Tripadvisor's longer narratives tend to document trade-offs and friction in fuller detail.
- Booking.com's hotel-only focus narrows the range of issues discussed and cleanly separates positives from negatives making it excellent for identifying "fixable" accommodation pain points.
- Google Maps reviews are generally shorter and more spontaneous, often capturing immediate satisfaction and practical wins (tours, transport, casual dining) rather than exhaustive critique, resulting in the highest overall sentiment and rating

3.5.1 Signals Consistent Across Platforms

1) Diving and marine experiences are the clearest "hero" asset

Diving is the strongest and most consistent theme across all platforms, both in sentiment and frequency of mention. On Tripadvisor, it records the highest theme sentiment and rating. On Google Maps, it remains highly positive and frequently referenced.

Regardless of whether visitors write long, reflective reviews or quick practical ones, the marine product reliably exceeds expectations and functions as a credible differentiator.

2) Activities and tours perform best when assessed through practical experience

Google Maps shows this most clearly: "Activity" is a standout category—ranking Timor-Leste #1 in activity sentiment among the four destinations. This suggests that when travelers talk about what they did (tours, excursions, on-the-ground experiences), Timor-Leste's product strength becomes more visible.

On Tripadvisor, attractions receive high ratings but lower sentiment. This suggests that while visitors clearly enjoy these experiences, they often describe them in factual or descriptive terms rather than emotionally enthusiastic language. The experience performs well, but its impact is not always strongly expressed in post-trip reflection. While the activity offer is strong, its emotional value is not always translated into vivid storytelling or advocacy.

3) Transport is an unexpected, repeatable strength

Both Tripadvisor and Google Maps independently surface transport as a top performer. This consistency matters: transport is not a niche tourism product—it's a core enabler of satisfaction. It also supports a broader positioning implication: visitors feel Timor-Leste is workable and navigable on the ground (drivers, transfers, practical movement), even if other infrastructure areas still lag.

4) Beaches and scenery are strong—and appear stronger when "discovered" rather than "evaluated"

Beaches perform well on Tripadvisor and even more strongly on Google Maps. In cross-destination comparisons, Timor-Leste outperforms Indonesia on beach sentiment within Google reviews.

Taken together, this points to a “hidden gem” effect: when visitors encounter beaches directly, satisfaction is high, but this does not always translate into the more comparative, detail-heavy evaluation style seen on Tripadvisor.

5) Hospitality is warmly perceived in practical contexts, but trails the region’s most polished competitor

Staff and friendliness trend positive across all platforms. However, benchmarking against Indonesia on Tripadvisor shows gaps in service-related themes such as staff, breakfast, and rooms.

This does not indicate poor hospitality. Rather, it suggests that while human warmth is a clear strength, consistency and service standards vary across properties and contexts, limiting how often experiences are described as exceptional.

3.5.2 Friction and Difficulty: What Gets in the Way (and Where It Concentrates)

If Timor-Leste’s strengths lie in experiences and human interaction, points of friction concentrate most clearly in accommodation reliability and connectivity. These issues appear across all platforms, but are most clearly revealed by platforms designed to assess hotels and tourism systems.

1) WiFi is the clearest cross-platform infrastructure pain point

Across platforms, Wi-Fi emerges as the most consistent pain point. On Booking.com, it is the most negatively discussed theme in disliked commentary. On Tripadvisor, Wi-Fi records both the lowest sentiment score and the lowest theme rating, indicating that connectivity issues extend beyond accommodation complaints and shape broader perceptions of comfort and ease.

Wi-Fi appears less frequently in Google Maps reviews and with lower intensity. Nevertheless, where connectivity is mentioned, it consistently weakens sentiment.

2) Accommodation fundamentals matter more than upgrades

Booking.com’s liked/disliked structure highlights a key pattern: quality varies widely across properties. Many accommodations deliver very positive experiences, but reliability is uneven.

Breakfast illustrates this point. It is praised when done well and criticized sharply when expectations are not met, pointing to high variance rather than a consistently weak offer. Similar patterns appear for rooms, bathrooms, and hot water or water reliability, elements that may be tolerated by some travelers, but become strong sources of dissatisfaction when they fail.

Tripadvisor's cross-destination comparison reinforces this finding. Themes such as rooms and breakfast trail Indonesia by a meaningful margin, suggesting that consistency, maintenance, and basic standards matter more to perception than the addition of higher-end features.

3) Attractions are enjoyed, but not strongly articulated

Tripadvisor's attraction category provides a key signal: attractions have the highest average rating but the lowest sentiment. This suggests visitors are satisfied, yet their language is more descriptive than emotive—likely reflecting fewer "wow" moments in the way experiences are packaged, interpreted, or guided, rather than the absence of value.

3.5.3 Audience Fit: Who Is Most Satisfied (and Where Expectations May Be Misaligned)

Booking.com adds segmentation insight that the other platforms don't do consistently: traveler type. Timor-Leste's accommodation feedback is not only positive overall; it also indicates a strong audience fit for key segments.

- **Families** provide the strongest ratings, with moderate-to-strong sentiment
- **Couples** are also highly satisfied
- **Solo travelers** represent the largest volume and stay the longest on average, suggesting that Timor-Leste attracts independent travelers who are willing to spend time and navigate complexity

Even with infrastructure friction (WiFi, water reliability, breakfast variance), overall satisfaction remains high among the segments most likely to travel to an emerging destination. In other words, Timor-Leste is not failing on experience, it is challenged most by *reliability* and *consistency*, which are solvable and often locally actionable.

4. International Media and Influencer Narratives

This section returns upstream in the digital travel journey to examine how Timor-Leste is framed during the Awareness and early Researching stages through international media and influencer narratives.

Unlike visitor reviews, which reflect lived experience, media and influencer content shape first impressions before planning begins. They influence how effort, authenticity, accessibility, and reward are perceived, and therefore play a critical role in determining whether travelers progress from curiosity into structured trip evaluation.

By analyzing how Timor-Leste is introduced, contextualized, and compared to regional destinations, this section assesses whether earned narratives strengthen or slow progression between Awareness and Researching, the transition where digital demand for the destination most frequently weakens.

The analysis draws on a curated dataset of international media articles and long-form influencer content with full text or transcripts. It examines which narratives dominate international coverage, how consistently they appear across sources, and how they may either support or slow the progression from curiosity to consideration. This allows for thematic, tonal, and comparative analysis across sources, and against selected peer destinations. A full list of sources is provided in Annex A.

4.1 Scope & Role of International Coverage

The media analysis is based on 19 international journalistic and editorial articles published by established outlets in the travel, lifestyle, and general-interest press. These include international travel publications (such as Adventure.com and National Geographic), as well as broader media outlets (including Business Insider and CNN). Together, these sources represent a mix of specialist travel media, regional lifestyle titles, and international press coverage that places Timor-Leste within wider cultural, regional, and geopolitical contexts.

Across these sources, media coverage typically adopts an explanatory and contextual tone. Articles often serve as reference material during early-stage destination research, particularly for travelers who are unfamiliar with Timor-Leste. Rather than focusing only on tourism experiences, media narratives frequently combine travel content with background on history, national identity, access, and infrastructure.

The media analysis focuses on three questions:

- Which framing narratives are most commonly used to describe Timor-Leste
- How access, infrastructure, and tourism experiences are explained and contextualized
- How Timor-Leste is positioned in relation to competing destinations

Influencer content in this assessment consists of 17 pieces of long-form, first-hand material produced by independent creators. This includes personal travel blogs, YouTube travel and adventure videos, and

narrative-driven storytelling formats. Video content ranges from niche productions with a few thousand views to widely circulated travel films reaching several hundred thousand viewers. This range allows the analysis to consider both reach and resonance.

Where available, engagement indicators such as view counts were retained to help contextualize influence and signal amplification potential.

The influencer analysis aims to:

- understand how lived travel experiences in Timor-Leste are communicated
- identify narratives that shift expectations (for example, “better than expected” framing)
- assess whether influencer storytelling reduces or amplifies perceived friction

Overall, influencer narratives often help translate Timor-Leste from an abstract or unfamiliar destination into a more relatable and navigable experience. By showing how travel unfolds in practice, this content can help bridge the gap between curiosity and confidence, making influencers particularly influential at the early consideration stage.

4.2 Media Framing Patterns

International media coverage of Timor-Leste is consistently positive in tone, with no net-negative sentiment identified across the articles reviewed. However, most coverage introduces background, context, and challenges before describing the travel experience itself. This ordering can unintentionally increase perceptions of effort and complexity before readers understand what the destination offers.

As a result, media coverage builds credibility and legitimacy, but often does so at the expense of immediacy, emotional engagement, and planning confidence.

4.2.1 Opening Framing of the Destination

A defining characteristic of international media coverage is the use of explanatory framing before experiential description. In 84% of traditional media articles opening paragraphs prioritize geographic clarification, historical background, or developmental context.

Common opening frames include:

- Geographic clarification (e.g. one of the world’s youngest nations, Southeast Asia’s least-visited country)
- Historical anchoring (references to independence, resilience, or post-conflict identity)
- Positioning signals (off the beaten path, not for everyone, requires context to appreciate)

The consistent prioritization of explanation over experiential benefit increases psychological distance between awareness and consideration. For travelers without prior familiarity or intrinsic motivation, this may function as a subtle but meaningful barrier to further engagement.

4.2.2 Marine Tourism: Strong Credibility, Weak Translation to Action

Marine and diving experiences generate the strongest and most consistent positive sentiment in international media coverage. The marine theme appears in 94.7% of media articles. Lexical patterns are highly convergent across publications, with repeated use of descriptors such as:

- pristine
- untouched
- world-class
- among the region's healthiest reefs

This consistency establishes high credibility and positions Timor-Leste as a serious marine destination rather than a curiosity. However, a key limitation emerges: positive framing is rarely accompanied by practical guidance.

Only 32% of marine-related passages include operational details such as

- where diving occurs
- how sites are accessed
- what infrastructure exists
- or how a visitor might realistically integrate diving into a trip.

As a result, media coverage validates marine quality without reducing planning uncertainty. Marine tourism strengthens Timor-Leste's reputation but does not reliably advance travelers from awareness into consideration or itinerary formation.

4.2.3 Culture and History

Cultural authenticity and historical narratives appear in all analyzed media articles, with moderately positive sentiment. These narratives emphasize resilience, lived culture, and national identity, and are often expressed through moral or symbolic language rather than through specific, concrete experiences.

Culture is presented as something to encounter and respect, but less often as something that can be planned, sequenced, or chosen in advance. This framing clearly differentiates Timor-Leste from more commodified destinations and reinforces its sense of authenticity. At the same time, it introduces uncertainty for travelers who need predictability when planning a trip. Cultural experiences are rarely described as time-bound or location-specific activities, and information about access or duration is often missing.

The result is a strong symbolic image of the destination, but limited practical clarity. Cultural narratives successfully generate curiosity and intrinsic motivation, yet they do not consistently support the practical decision factors—such as trip length, activity selection, or feasibility—that travelers rely on when moving toward booking.

4.2.4 Friction Narratives Introduce Effort Early

Access and logistical considerations appear in ~74% of media articles, with mention typically occurring in the first third of the narrative. Accommodation and infrastructure themes generate the lowest sentiment of any media theme, and sentiment polarity correlates negatively with mention frequency in logistical contexts.

Friction is rarely framed as failure. Instead, constraints are normalized as inherent characteristics of the destination. Common terms include:

- “challenging” or “difficult”
- “limited infrastructure”
- “requires planning”

In a majority of articles, friction is introduced before experiential benefits are fully established. This sequencing increases the salience of perceived costs before emotional engagement is achieved.

For risk-averse or unfamiliar travelers, early exposure to effort-related language may activate uncertainty avoidance mechanisms, suppressing progression into deeper consideration, even when overall sentiment remains positive.

4.2.5 Comparative Anchoring: Indonesia as Reference Point

Explicit comparisons to Indonesia, Bali, or regional benchmarks appear in more than half of media articles. These references help readers locate Timor-Leste geographically, but they also anchor evaluation to mature tourism systems with higher expectations of ease, scale, and service consistency.

Common comparative frames include:

- Near Indonesia but very different
- Less developed than Bali
- Not like typical Southeast Asia

Such comparisons introduce reference-dependent evaluation. While contrast is often emphasized, the comparator itself implicitly sets expectations around infrastructure and convenience. This can disadvantage Timor-Leste on effort-related dimensions even when experiential quality is strong or distinctive.

Comparative anchoring therefore has a dual effect: it improves cognitive clarity while simultaneously elevating perceived effort through expectation transfer.

4.2.6 Overall Media Consensus

International media coverage plays an important role in helping people hear about Timor-Leste and view it as a credible and worthwhile destination. However, on its own, it rarely prompts travelers to begin serious trip planning. Across the articles analyzed, media coverage presents Timor-Leste as valuable, authentic, and distinctive, particularly in relation to its marine and cultural assets. This establishes trust and legitimacy.

At the same time, many stories introduce explanation, context, and logistical challenges before clearly showing what visitors can do, how rewarding the experience is, or how trips are typically organized. As a result, positive attitudes do not always translate into planning confidence or behavioral intention.

In practical terms, international media mainly builds awareness of Timor-Leste, rather than motivating travelers to actively plan a trip.

Without more narratives that show concrete experiences, typical itineraries, and how common concerns are managed in practice, media exposure alone is unlikely to generate sustained planning behavior. This helps explain why international media coverage could produce short-term spikes in awareness without translating into a lasting increase in baseline attention toward the destination.

4.3 Influencer Framing Patterns

Influencer content presents a different picture of Timor-Leste than traditional international media. While media coverage tends to explain the destination from a distance, influencer narratives are grounded in first-hand experience and personal storytelling. As a result, they often feel more immediate, relatable, and practical for audiences considering a visit.

Overall, influencer coverage of Timor-Leste is strongly positive in tone. These narratives show that rewarding travel experiences are possible, even in a destination that may appear unfamiliar or logistically complex.

However, similar to the international media studied, the influencer content currently available does not consistently provide the structure or reassurance needed by broader audiences. Experiences are often shown as individual moments or short visits, rather than as complete, clearly organized trips.

In practice, influencer content functions more as an expectation calibrator than as a broad demand driver. While explainer-style formats do exist in general (such as day-by-day vlogs or “how I planned my trip” content), they are not prominent or consistently visible in influencer coverage of Timor-Leste. As a result, content shows what is possible in the destination, but rarely explains how a typical visitor would plan, sequence, or manage a trip from start to finish.

4.3.1 Naming Patterns Use Unfamiliarity and Exploration as Primary Hooks

Analysis of titles and opening frames reveals an emphasis on unfamiliarity and challenge rather than accessibility or ease. Across creators and publication years, influencer titles assume low prior awareness and frame Timor-Leste as something to be discovered, tested, or experienced personally.

Dominant title patterns include:

- Unfamiliarity / rarity framing (e.g. “What is EAST-TIMOR?”, “Least Visited Country”)
- Time-bounded exploration (e.g. “48 Hours in Timor Leste”)
- Challenge / difficulty framing: (e.g. “Most Unknown Land Border”, “Terrible Roads”)
- Personal milestone framing (e.g. “Country #99”)

These frames position Timor-Leste as a challenge destination rather than a broadly accessible leisure option, limiting appeal to mid-centric and comfort-oriented travelers who dominate global tourism demand.

4.3.2 Experience Outperforms Infrastructure

While influencer content shows higher overall sentiment than traditional media, this advantage is unevenly distributed across themes.

Key divergences between influencer and media sentiment include:

- **Food**: Food is the highest-sentiment theme in influencer content, reflecting personal interaction, cultural immersion, and accessibility of experience.
- **Nature**: Visual and experiential emphasis aligns with video-first platforms.
- **Accommodation**: Accommodation is the only theme with neutral-to-negative sentiment in influencer content, indicating heightened scrutiny of service consistency and comfort.

This pattern indicates that influencers amplify experiential authenticity while applying more critical standards to infrastructure and accommodation. For experienced travelers, this reinforces credibility. For risk-averse travelers, it may amplify concern.

4.3.3 What Influencers Emphasize

Comparison of thematic mention frequency shows strong alignment on core destination attributes, but notable differences in emphasis:

Table 4.3A: Media vs Influencer Theme Mention Rates

Theme	Media Mention Rate	Influencer Mention Rate	Difference
Culture	100%	94.1%	–5.9%

Nature	100%	94.1%	–5.9%
Diving	94.7%	88.2%	–6.5%
Beaches	84.2%	94.1%	+9.9%
Food	68.4%	94.1%	+25.7%
Hotels	84.2%	88.2%	+4.0%

Food shows the greatest difference between influencer content and visitor reviews, reflecting influencers' focus on everyday cultural experiences and sensory detail. Importantly, influencers do not avoid discussing accommodation or infrastructure, even when these topics carry negative sentiment. This suggests they are aiming for credibility rather than polished promotion.

Overall, influencers function primarily as experience validators—showing what travel feels like—rather than as guides for trip planning or explanations of how systems work.

4.3.4 Experience Framing: Episodic Rather Than Structured

Narrative structure analysis reveals that influencer content is predominantly episodic rather than systematic:

- Short-duration framing ("48 hours")
- Single-location focus (e.g. Atauro, Dili, Balibo)
- Challenge-specific narratives

This confirms that compelling experiences exist, but it rarely shows how those experiences fit together into a multi-day visit. Viewers see what can be done, but not how a trip is typically structured, paced, or planned.

For experienced and adventure-oriented travelers, this kind of storytelling can be reassuring—it shows that rewarding travel is possible even with limited infrastructure. For first-time or more mainstream travelers, however, the lack of structure makes it harder to imagine what a realistic visit would look like, which could be slowing progression into planning.

4.3.5 What Influencers Do—and Do Not—Do for Demand

What influencer narratives do well:

- Validate destination quality through personal testimony (88.2% positive sentiment)
- Demonstrate experiential richness, especially food and nature
- Humanize the destination through lived interaction

- Reduce uncertainty for travelers already inclined to visit

What influencer narratives do not do:

- Resolve infrastructure or accommodation concerns
- Provide structured planning guidance
- Reposition Timor-Leste as easy or predictable
- Expand appeal beyond novelty-seeking audiences
- Connect consistently with official destination channels

Influencer content related to Timor-Leste currently operates largely outside of official destination channels. While the official Facebook page shows recent activity, influencer content appears only intermittently and is not consistently tagged, curated, commented on, or integrated into a broader content flow. The official Instagram account exists but has not been actively maintained in recent years, and basic traveler questions that have been posted as comments—such as those related to visa requirements—can remain unanswered.

As a result, influencer narratives circulate independently rather than functioning as gateways into authoritative destination information. Even when influencer content is reshared, it is not systematically connected to official websites, planning resources, or practical guidance that would help interested viewers progress toward concrete trip planning.

In practical terms, this means that influencer visibility is not currently linked to official digital touchpoints—such as destination websites or social channels—that provide clear itineraries, logistical guidance, pricing context, or answers to common traveler questions.

Any future effort to leverage influencers more effectively would therefore depend first on establishing consistent, responsive official channels that can receive, contextualize, and extend that visibility into tangible planning support.

4.4 Narrative Tensions & Structural Gaps

Across both international media and influencer coverage, Timor-Leste is presented in a positive and credible way. No net-negative sentiment appears in the material reviewed, and key destination strengths—marine quality, cultural authenticity, and natural landscapes—are consistently confirmed. Awareness and legitimacy are therefore not the main constraints on demand.

The main constraint lies in how these stories are told and what information they leave out. Media and influencer narratives often spend more time explaining background, challenges, or uniqueness than showing how a visit actually works in practice. As a result, readers and viewers may understand that Timor-Leste is interesting, but aren’t led to how they would plan and manage a trip themselves.

Travelers are frequently told that Timor-Leste is authentic, distinctive, and off the beaten path, but are rarely shown what a typical visit looks like. Practical reference points—such as how many days visitors usually stay, which locations are commonly combined, or how travel between places is handled—are often missing. Without these signals, positive impressions do not consistently translate into active trip planning.

In international media, this gap is most visible in marine and cultural coverage. Diving and marine experiences are regularly described as pristine and world-class, but articles often stop short of explaining where diving takes place, how visitors reach the sites, or whether experiences are suitable for beginners. Cultural stories highlight depth, resilience, and meaning, but rarely describe specific, bookable experiences such as guided walks, village visits, or market activities. Logistical challenges are mentioned early, but are not balanced with reassurance that these challenges are commonly managed through local guides, short distances, or established visitor routes.

Influencer content shows that enjoyable trips to Timor-Leste are possible, but usually through highly personal or episodic storytelling. Most content focuses on short stays, single locations, or particularly adventurous moments. While this can be inspiring, it can make the experience difficult for broader audiences to replicate. Practical explanations—such as how transport is arranged, where visitors typically stay, or how comfort levels vary by location—are often absent.

Taken together, these narratives tend to appeal most strongly to experienced or highly flexible travelers who are comfortable with uncertainty.

From a media and awareness perspective, the priority is not primarily to increase positive sentiment, which already holds steady across international coverage.

Instead, the opportunity is to expand the volume and reach of coverage (increasing awareness at the top of the funnel), while also curating stories that show how visits typically work in practice. This includes introducing clearer signals around trip length, common location combinations, logistical simplicity, and available local support.

Without this translation from inspiration to practicality, international coverage is likely to continue generating awareness without consistently advancing travelers into structured trip planning.

5. Traveler Segments, Digital Behavior Signals, and Investment Relevance

This assessment identifies key traveler segments relevant to Timor-Leste based on patterns observed in international media and influencer coverage, including sentiment, thematic emphasis, and narrative structure. At this stage, traveler behavior is inferred from how different audiences are addressed, reassured, or filtered through digital storytelling, rather than from booking or conversion data.

The digital behavior insights presented here therefore describe how different traveler types are likely to discover, interpret, and validate Timor-Leste online—not how they ultimately book or convert. These inferences are grounded in the narrative and sentiment patterns previously discussed and are intended to inform early-stage market relevance and investment alignment.

5.1 Product-Led Traveler Segmentation

Traveler segments are defined in relation to priority tourism products identified in national tourism policy and investment frameworks, including eco-adventure, marine tourism, cultural experiences, and emerging high-value niches such as sailing and yachting. This approach ensures that observed digital demand signals are assessed in direct relation to investment priorities. Across these product areas, four traveler segments consistently emerge as relevant to Timor-Leste's current digital positioning.

5.1.1 Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature, and Solo Travelers

Digital narratives strongly support independent and flexible travelers motivated by novelty, nature, and personal discovery. Both international media and influencer content present remoteness and effort as expected elements of the experience, without triggering negative sentiment. This indicates a traveler segment with high tolerance for uncertainty and logistical ambiguity.

Influencer content in particular reinforces this positioning through episodic storytelling and challenge-based framing, where difficulty is treated as part of the appeal rather than a barrier. Even when access constraints or infrastructure limitations are mentioned, sentiment remains positive, suggesting that these travelers actively seek, rather than avoid, such conditions.

Observed digital behavior signals:

- Discovery via long-form media, blogs, and YouTube
- Validation through influencer testimony and peer narratives
- Lower dependence on step-by-step planning content at the awareness stage

This segment is already digitally reachable and aligned with eco-adventure investment priorities that emphasize low-impact, experience-led development.

5.1.2 Marine, Diving, Sailing and Yachting Travelers

Marine-oriented travelers represent one of the strongest opportunity segments for Timor-Leste from both demand and investment perspectives. Sentiment analysis shows consistently high credibility around marine quality, with strong agreement across international media sources and the lowest variance of any theme.

However, marine narratives frequently stop short of practical detail. While diving, reefs, and marine biodiversity are praised, information about access, conditions, skill level, and supporting services is often missing. This suggests a digitally engaged audience that actively researches and compares destinations, but requires clear operational information before progressing beyond interest.

Observed digital behavior signals:

- Engagement with expert validation and comparative content
- Strong response to consistent, evidence-based quality claims
- Drop-off where operational guidance is missing (e.g. where, how, conditions)

This segment includes sailing and yachting travelers, for whom clarity around access, safety, services, and infrastructure will be essential.

5.1.3 Cultural, Experiential and Couple-Oriented Travelers

Cultural and experiential travelers are consistently addressed in international media through narratives of authenticity, resilience, and lived culture. Sentiment is positive across all reviewed sources, indicating strong symbolic appeal.

These narratives align well with couples seeking meaningful, experience-driven travel, particularly those interested in food, community interaction, and landscapes rather than luxury. However, culture is usually presented in abstract terms rather than as a set of clearly defined experiences.

As a result, travelers may understand why Timor-Leste is culturally distinctive, but struggle to see how cultural engagement fits into a trip in practical terms. The absence of detail around timing, locations, and activity structure introduces hesitation for those who require clearer planning signals.

Observed digital behavior signals:

- Reliance on editorial and official sources for legitimacy
- Interest in what makes the destination meaningful
- Need for translation from values to activities (e.g. what can be done, how long, where)

This segment is closely aligned with policy objectives around inclusive tourism and community engagement, but requires clearer digital storytelling to support progression from interest to planning.

5.1.4 Backpackers and Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers

Backpackers and budget-oriented travelers appear primarily in influencer narratives and peer-to-peer content, but are less visible in international media framing. Accommodation and infrastructure receive the most critical sentiment in influencer coverage, reflecting sensitivity to comfort, price, and service consistency.

Despite this, difficulty is normalized rather than avoided. These travelers actively discuss trade-offs related to transport, accommodation, and cost, and tend to frame friction as something to manage rather than a reason not to travel.

Observed digital behavior signals:

- Reliance on peer-to-peer content and influencer experience
- Active discussion of logistics and accommodation trade-offs
- High tolerance for variability, low tolerance for unclear costs

This segment contributes to visibility and early-stage demand but is less relevant as a primary driver of high-value investment.

Families and comfort-oriented travelers

Notably, current digital narratives do not actively target or reassure family travelers. Early introduction of logistical friction, weak accommodation sentiment, and absence of family-oriented reassurance signals suggest that families are implicitly filtered out by narrative structure rather than by negative perception.

This does not indicate lack of suitability, but rather absence of targeted messaging. Addressing this gap would require deliberate digital framing around ease, safety, predictability, and accommodation standards, elements not currently present in earned narratives.

5.2 Observed Digital Behavior Signals

This section consolidates the key digital behavior signals observed across priority traveler segments relevant to Timor-Leste. These signals describe how different traveler types currently encounter the destination online, how strengths and constraints are presented during discovery, and which types of information appear to support or slow movement from awareness to consideration.

The signals summarized below are drawn from international media coverage, influencer content, and sentiment analysis of publicly visible sources. They are intended to provide practical proxies for digital discovery and validation patterns in the absence of proprietary analytics.

5.2 - Traveler Segment Behavior Signals

Traveler segment	Core product alignment	Observed digital behavior signals	Evidence base	Investment relevance	Key gaps to address
Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Travelers	- Eco-adventures (guided outdoor activities with low environmental impact) - Trekking (multi-hour or multi-day walking routes, often linking landscapes or communities) - Nature (wildlife observation, remote beaches, coastal and forest landscapes) - Community-based experiences (local guiding, demonstrations, hosting)	- Discover destinations through long-form media and exploratory influencer content -Accept early friction framing - Validate interest through personal testimony rather than official reassurance - High tolerance for ambiguity	- Positive sentiment despite early friction - Challenge framing normalized in influencer narratives - Episodic content does not suppress interest	- High relevance for low-impact, eco-adventure investment - Fast activation potential	Limited need for reassurance, but lack of structured itineraries may constrain length of stay
Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Travelers	- Diving (guided shore or boat dives focused on reef ecosystems) - Snorkeling (shallow-water reef exploration accessible to non-specialists) - Reefs (high-biodiversity coral systems as a primary attraction) - Sailing / yachting (small-vessel or liveaboard marine travel, inter-island routes)	- Engage in expert-led research and cross-source validation - Respond strongly to consistent quality claims - Require operational clarity to progress beyond interest - Compare destinations digitally	- Highest sentiment and lowest variance for marine themes - Weak operational co-occurrence - Accommodation sentiment lag	- Very high investment relevance - Strong case for marine infrastructure, services, and high-value products	Missing clarity on access, conditions, safety, services, and integration into trips
Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented Travelers	- Cultural heritage (historical sites, traditions, rituals, and interpretive experiences) - Food (local markets, informal dining, traditional preparation) - Community interaction (shared meals, informal exchange, participation in daily life) - Soft nature (low-effort nature experiences such as beaches, short walks, scenic viewpoints)	- Discover via editorial media and official sources - Respond to symbolic authenticity - Moderate tolerance for uncertainty	- Universal cultural mention - High subjectivity - Culture framed abstractly rather than operationally	- High policy relevance - Supports inclusive tourism and dispersal	Culture not presented as plannable experiences
Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers	- Budget accommodation - Transport-light products	- Rely heavily on influencer and peer-to-peer validation - Actively discuss logistics and trade-offs - Tolerate infrastructure variability - Price- and value-sensitive	- Influencer accommodation sentiment divergence - Normalization of difficulty - Peer framing dominant	- Moderate relevance for visibility and ecosystem vitality - Lower priority for capital-intensive investment	Cost clarity, accommodation consistency, and transport transparency

These observations do not represent measured user behavior or conversion data, which will likely come with the successive reports. Rather, they provide evidence-based proxies for digital discovery and validation patterns in the absence of proprietary analytics, which will be addressed in subsequent outputs.

5.3 Data Gaps and Validation Path

The traveler segments and digital behavior signals identified in this assessment should be understood as a starting framework, not a final market prioritization. They reflect how Timor-Leste is currently discovered, interpreted, and evaluated online, based on publicly visible digital behavior.

Because this analysis relies on search data, international media coverage, influencer content, and visitor reviews, it provides strong insight into who is interested, how interest forms, and where it tends to stall. However, it does not directly reveal who ultimately converts, which source markets drive arrivals, or how digital interest translates into visitation and economic impact.

Several key questions therefore cannot be fully answered using public data alone:

- **Source market alignment**: Which origin markets most strongly convert into arrivals for each identified traveler segment
- **Relative segment size and growth**: The scale, growth trajectory, and value of each segment in physical visitation
- **Digital-to-physical pathways**: Which digital touchpoints most consistently support progression from awareness to planning and arrival
- **Product–market performance**: Which tourism products perform best by source market in terms of conversion, length of stay, and yield

With access to proprietary data from Timor-Leste, future analysis will validate and refine the preliminary segmentation identified in this assessment through a phased approach. Digital behavior validation will use website analytics and search data to confirm how different source markets engage with planning content and where progression from awareness to consideration occurs or breaks down.

Visitor profile and arrival data will be used to compare observed digital interest with actual visitation patterns, including source markets, length of stay, and participation in key activities. Survey-based refinement will clarify visitor motivations, decision drivers, perceived barriers, and reassurance needs, allowing segments to be tested against lived travel experience rather than inferred behavior alone.

Finally, market–segment prioritization will combine these inputs to identify high-potential product–market combinations, distinguish near-term activation opportunities from longer-term positioning needs, and support evidence-based investment and marketing decisions.

By combining public digital signals with proprietary data, future phases will provide a clear and actionable basis for focusing resources on the traveler segments and source markets with the strongest potential for sustainable growth.

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Annex A: Media & Influencer Sources

Publication	Article title	Author	Media/ Influencer	Publication date	Content type	Views (If video)
Seven Seas Media	Feature Destination: Why Atauro Island?	Seven Seas Media	Media		Article	
Adventure.com	Fewer than 10 tourists a day: Welcome to Timor-Leste	Christine Retschlag	Media	December 11, 2023	Article	
Divernet	Scuba Diving of Timor Leste	World Dives	Media	October 29, 2020	Article	
Macao News	For scuba divers seeking serenity, nothing beats Atauro Island		Media	January 11, 2024	Article	
Monga Bay	Unregulated tourism risks disrupting Timor-Leste's whale migration	Robin Hicks	Media	December 11, 2025	Article	
Business Insider	I Traveled Solo in Timor-Leste, the Least-Visited Country in Asia	Marielle Descalsota	Media	July 5, 2024	Article	
National Geographic	Ten Places That Deserve More Travelers	Tara Isabella Burton	Media	June 9, 2016	Article	
Scuba Travel	Scuba Diving Timor-Leste (East Timor)	Scuba Travel	Media	September 10, 2024	Article	
The Star	Time to explore the undiscovered wonders of Timor-Leste	Florey D Mikil	Media	June 30, 2025	Article	
Travel and Tour World	https://www.travelandtourworld.com/news/article/timor-leste-the-ultimate-off-the-beaten-path-destination/	Travel and Tour World	Media	January 14, 2026	Article	
Intrepid Travel	In a Father's Footsteps: Seeking Culture and Connection in Timor-Leste	Patrick Boxall	Media	July 22, 2024	Article	
Sydney Morning Herald | Traveller	Ten great destinations that want more tourists (and five that don't)	Ben Groundwater	Media	March 25, 2024	Article	
Street Food Guy	The Atauro Island Guide 2026 - The Street Food Guy	Gareth Johnson	Influencer	2026	Article	
Telegraph	The forgotten tropical outpost on the brink of a tourism boom	Michelle Jana Chan	Media	December 10, 2023	Article	
Oceanographic Magazine	Time immemorial: Traditions in Timor Leste	Mads St Clair	Media	2024	Article	

The ASEAN	Timor-Leste's Reefs and Peaks: Discover a New Adventure - The ASEAN Magazine	Ministry of Tourism and Environment, Timor-Leste	Media	January 6, 2026	Article	
Go Nomad	Visiting Timor-Leste: The Country No One Knows Exists	Jenny Lundt	Media	December 2019	Article	
CNN	Where to travel in 2026	CNN Travel Team	Media	December 31, 2025	Article	
Three Best Friends Abroad	East Timor | The New Kid on the Block	Blog Owner	Influencer	March 6, 2024	Blog	
Road to 197	Trip Report: Timor-Leste – Country #192	Nicolai	Influencer	August 29, 2025	Blog	
Take Your Backpack	Dili, Timor-Leste City Guide - Neighborhoods & Where to Stay	Johan	Influencer	July 24, 2025	Destination Guide	
X-Ray Mag	Timor-Leste: Off the Beaten Path | X-Ray Mag	Brandi Mueller	Media	Not Specified	Dive Magazine	
World Away From Home	Timor-Leste Travel Guide: What to Expect in Asia's Least-Visited Country	Tyreek	Influencer	Not Specified	Travelogue	
	48 Hours in Timor Leste || Dili Travel Vlog	The Traveling ZAM	Influencer	August 26, 2024	Video	32,463
	48 Hours in Timor Leste 🇹🇱 Exploring Atauro Island and Balibo (real East Timor)	Dabble and Travel	Influencer	January 7, 2025	Video	39,055
	Crossing The Most Unknown Land Border On Foot 🇹🇱	Backpacker Ben	Influencer	October 30, 2023	Video	105,599
	Retracing WW2 history in East Timor 🇹🇱 Riding Timor's terrible roads Ep16 RTW	Riding on Eggshells	Influencer	September 16, 2022	Video	6,421
	She Cooks for 100 People! (in Timor-Leste)	Drew Binsky	Influencer	May 18, 2018	Video	63,855
	Timor Leste Exploring Cristo Red and Whale Watching - Country #99 - YouTube	Kendrick Uy	Influencer	November 21, 2023	Video	152
	What is EAST-TIMOR? 🇹🇱 Unveiling Southeast Asia's Least Visited Country! - YouTube	Little Chinese Everywhere	Influencer	May 11, 2024	Video	481,229

	2024 Year in Review & 2025 Preview - HoneyTrek - Couples Adventure Travel	HoneyTrek (Mike & Anne)	Influencer			
	Travel to Timor-Leste	Chris Christensen	Influencer			
	Timor-Leste Coast2Coast – Around Same and Betano Beach	Jonty Crane	Influencer			
	A Backpackers Guide to East Timor	Johnny Ward	Influencer			
	Highlights from Timor-Leste	Emily Lush	Influencer			
Scubadiving.com	Protecting the Sea Turtles of Timor-Leste | Scuba Diving	Dr. Daniel Flormann	Media	August 8, 2025		

Annex B: Key Digital & Tourism Marketing Terms Used in This Report

This report uses selected digital and tourism-system terms to describe how travel demand forms and progresses online. These terms are explained below in plain language to support shared understanding across stakeholders. A few additional terms are included to provide broader context, particularly around booking behaviors that can be relevant to private industry stakeholders.

Funnel & Demand Concepts (in a Travel-Marketing Context)

- Awareness - The stage when potential travelers first become aware of a destination. At this point, they may recognize the name but are not yet actively planning a trip.
- Consideration - The stage when a traveler begins actively evaluating whether a destination fits their interests, budget, and timing. This is where comparisons, research, and validation increase.
- Conversion - The point at which interest turns into a concrete action, such as booking a flight, accommodation, or tour. Conversion reflects movement from planning to commitment. This is more often used with private industry stakeholders.
- Conversion Rate - The percentage of people who take a desired action (such as booking) after visiting a website or engaging with content. Low conversion rates can signal uncertainty, lack of trust, or missing information.
- Drop-off - The point in the travel decision process where potential travelers lose momentum and stop progressing toward booking.
- Mid-Funnel - The stage between awareness and booking, when travelers are actively researching and comparing options. This stage builds toward planning confidence.
- Planning-Stage Behavior - Searches or online actions that indicate a traveler is organizing a trip (e.g., searching for itineraries, hotels, or transport options). These behaviors signal deeper intent than general curiosity.
- Top of Funnel - The earliest stage of interest formation, where travelers are learning about a destination for the first time. Media coverage and social content often operate at this level.

Behavior & Sentiment Concepts

- Aspect-Level Sentiment - Analysis that measures how visitors feel about specific elements of their experience (e.g., Wi-Fi, breakfast, staff), rather than evaluating the overall review as a whole.
- Early Friction - Language or signals that introduce effort, difficulty, or uncertainty early in a narrative, before benefits are fully explained. Early friction can slow progression from awareness to planning.
- Expectation-Setting - The process by which travelers form assumptions about quality, comfort, logistics, and experience before arrival. Clear expectation-setting reduces disappointment and negative sentiment.

- Narrative Framing - The way a destination story is structured or introduced (e.g., focusing first on history, difficulty, or uniqueness). Framing influences how travelers interpret information and risk.
- Sentiment - A measure of the emotional tone expressed in reviews, media, or online content. Sentiment can be positive, neutral, or negative, and helps reveal perception patterns.

Digital Visibility Concepts

- Branded Search - A search query that includes the official name of a destination, company, or brand (e.g., “Visit Timor-Leste”). Branded search often reflects existing awareness.
- Click-Through - When a user clicks on a search result, article, or advertisement to visit a website. Click-through behavior signals interest beyond simple visibility.
- Impressions - The number of times a webpage, article, or search result appears in front of users while they’re using a search engine. Impressions reflect visibility, even if users do not click.
- Keyword - A word or phrase that users type into search engines when looking for information. Keyword patterns reveal what people want to know about a destination.
- Long-Tail Search - More specific search phrases that include qualifiers such as trip length, activity type, or location (e.g., “7-day Timor-Leste itinerary”). Long-tail searches signal deeper planning intent. Their more specialized nature usually means the search volume is lower.
- Organic Search - Website visits that come from unpaid search engine results. Strong organic visibility indicates that a destination is discoverable without advertising.
- Search Intent - The purpose behind a search query, such as learning (informational), comparing (commercial), or booking (transactional). Intent helps identify where travelers are in the decision process.
- Site Visit - When a user lands on and browses a website. Site visits indicate movement from awareness into active information-seeking.

Influencer/Media Concepts

- Earned Media - Publicity generated through independent media coverage rather than paid advertising. Earned media builds credibility and awareness but is less controllable.
- Expert Validation - Credibility built when specialists (e.g., divers, journalists, experienced travelers) confirm the quality of a destination or product. This is especially important in niche segments.
- Influencer - An independent content creator who shares travel experiences with an online audience. Influencers shape perception through personal storytelling and first-hand demonstration.
- Validation - The process by which travelers confirm that a destination meets their expectations, often through reviews, testimonials, or trusted third-party content.

Tourism System Terms

- Digital Touchpoint **-** Any online interaction a traveler has with a destination before, during, or after a trip (e.g., search results, websites, reviews, social media, booking platforms). Different touchpoints influence different stages of decision-making.
- Distribution Channel - The platform or pathway through which travel products are marketed and sold, such as tour operators, online travel agencies (OTAs), or direct booking websites. Strong distribution increases visibility and access to markets.
- International Tour Operator - A company based outside the destination that packages and sells trips to international travelers. ITO representation increases structured demand and provides planning reassurance.
- On-the-Ground Operator - A locally based company that delivers tours, transport, accommodation, or experiences within the destination. Their quality and reliability directly shape visitor satisfaction and reputation.
- Online Travel Agency (OTA) - A digital platform (such as Booking.com or Expedia) where travelers search for and book accommodation, tours, or flights. OTAs play a major role in shaping visibility and price comparisons.
- Product–Market Fit - The degree to which a destination's tourism products align with the expectations, preferences, and behaviors of a specific traveler segment. Strong fit leads to higher satisfaction and repeat visitation.
- Service Consistency - The reliability of core visitor services (such as rooms, breakfast, Wi-Fi, transport) across different providers and locations. Inconsistent delivery increases the risk of negative sentiment even when overall experiences are positive.
- Tourism Value Chain - The sequence of services that together create a visitor's experience—from discovery and booking to transport, accommodation, activities, and post-trip reviews. Weakness at any point can affect overall perception.
- Visitor Journey - The full pathway a traveler follows from first awareness of a destination through planning, booking, travel, and post-visit sharing. Different policies and digital actions influence different stages of this journey.